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THE RISING NEPAL

ALL BE HAPPY, ALL BE WELL

Nepal, India ink power trade deal

High-level Joint Commission meeting held

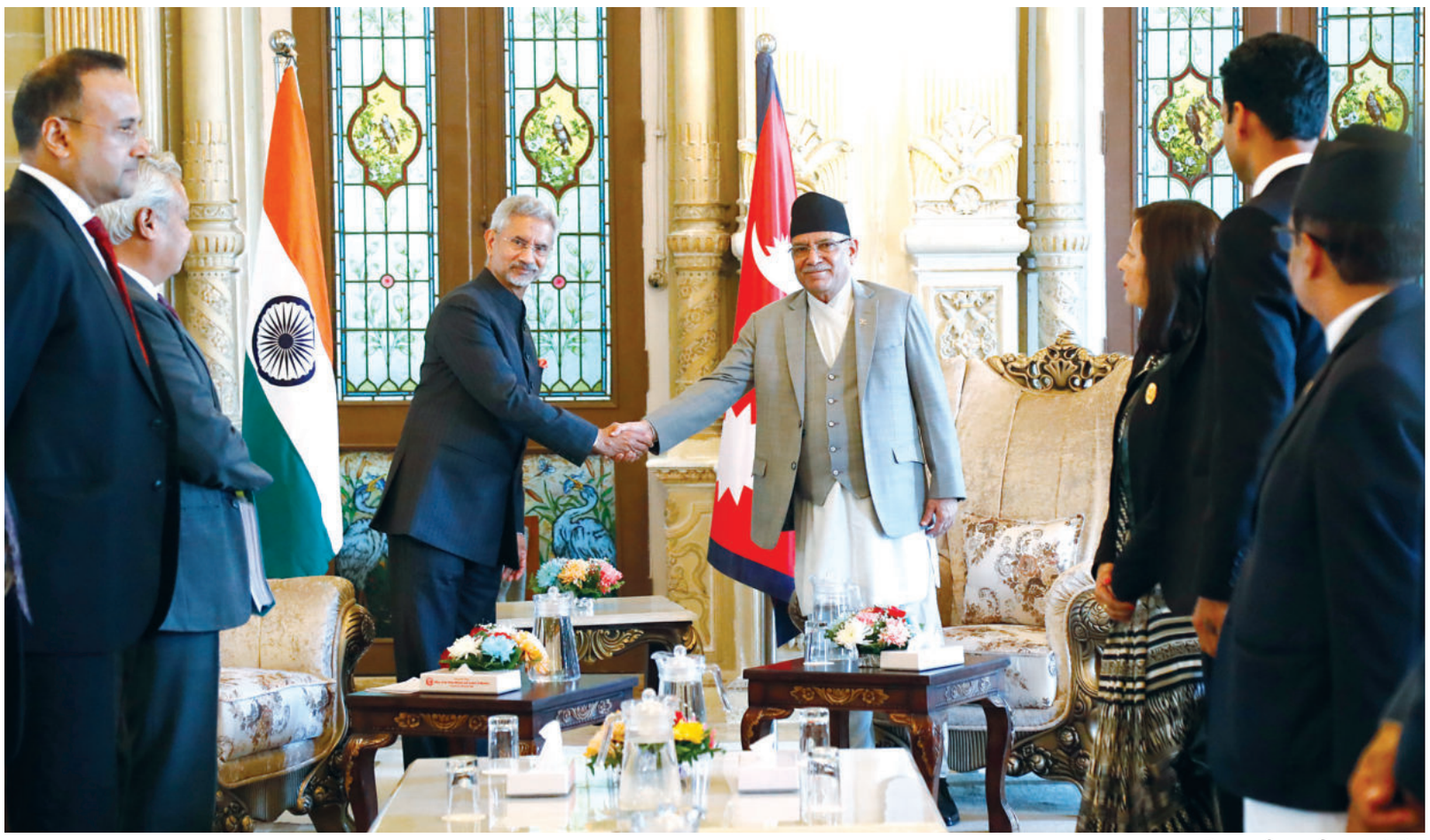


PHOTO: SUJAN GURUNG/TRN

External Affairs Minister of India S. Jaishankar calls on Prime Minister Pushpa Kamal Dahal 'Prachanda' at Singha Durbar in Kathmandu on Thursday.

BY MODNATH DHAKAL
Kathmandu, Jan. 4

Nepal and India have signed a pact on a long-term electricity trade materialising the Memorandum of Understanding (MoU) signed between the two countries during the visit of Prime Minister Pushpa Kamal Dahal 'Prachanda' to India in May-June last year.

The agreement that will facilitate about 10,000 Megawatts electricity to India in a decade has been signed at the high-level seventh Nepal-India Joint Commission meeting held in Kathmandu on Thursday.

Energy secretaries of Nepal and India Gopal Sigdel and Pankaj Agrawal signed the agreement in the presence of Minister for Energy, Water Resources and Irrigation Shakti Bahadur Basnet. The JC meeting was co-chaired by Minister for Foreign Affairs, NP Saud of Nepal and Minister for External Affairs, Dr. S Jaishankar of India.

The Government of Nepal has formulated an Energy Development Strategy with an aim to generate 28,000 MWs electricity in the next 12 years, and more than half of it would be exported to India and other regional markets.

Being the nearest market as well power-hungry developing bordering states Bihar and Uttar Pradesh, India is the most favourable destination for Nepal in terms of energy trade although discussions are underway also with Bangladesh and China. Bangladesh has been expressing interest to invest in a project worth US$ 1 billion and import electricity from Nepal.

An MoU for Co-operation in the Renewable Energy Development Between Nepal Electricity Authority (NEA) and NTPC Limited was also signed during the meeting.

Likewise, the Ministry of Foreign Affairs (MoFA) informed that the two ministers also jointly inaugurated, in virtual mode, three 132 kV cross-border transmission lines between India and Nepal, namely, the second circuit of Raxaul-Parwanipur line, the second circuit of Kataiya-Kusaha line, and the New Nautanwa-Mainhiya line. These infrastructures will facilitate in seamless flow of electricity between the two countries.

Rs. 200 million grant projects

Likewise, the meeting also exchanged an agreement between Government of Nepal and Government of India regarding Indian Grant Assistance for the Implementation of High Impact Community Development Projects (HICDPs). Maximum budget of each of such projects would be Rs. 200 million,

The new agreement has replaced the earlier Small Projects Development Grant Agreement signed in August 2008 and renewed on August 9, 2023.

It was signed by Finance Secretary, Dr. Krishna Hari Pushkar and Indian Ambassador to Nepal, Naveen Srivastava in the presence of Foreign Minister Saud of Nepal and External Affairs Minister of India Dr. Jaishankar.

According to the Ministry of Finance (MoF), projects under the Indian grant would be as per the demands of the local bodies or other government agencies under the inspection and recommendation of such demands by the Ministry of Federal Affairs and General Administration (MoFAGA) of Nepal to the MoF. The Finance Ministry would request the Government of India for grant support to implement such projects on the basis of priority.

"Even in the case of the non-government organisations, the projects should be recommended by the line ministry and approved by the Social Welfare Council with the consent from the MoF," read a statement issued by the MoF on Thursday. These projects will be implemented by including in the budget of the respective level of the government with a tripartite agreement between the MoFAGA, Embassy of India in Kathmandu and concerned implementation agency. As per the new provisions, project implementing rural municipality should contribute 5 per cent and municipality 10 per cent counterpart fund. There would be a project monitoring committee including federal and local stakeholders and representative from the Embassy of India in Nepal.

India to launch Nepal's Munal

Meanwhile, Nepal Academy of Science and Technology (NAST) and New

» SEE PAGE 6

Spirit of coalition won't be undermined: PM Prachanda

BY NAWARAJ SHRESTHA
Ramechhap, Jan. 4

Prime Minister Pushpa Kamal Dahal 'Prachanda' has said that the current ruling coalition will complete its full five-year term.

Inaugurating a building of Sunapati Rural Municipality in Ramechhap on Thursday, Prime Minister Prachanda said, "This coalition will last its full term. There is no 'if and but' and there is no need to doubt it."

Prime Minister Prachanda, who is also the chairman of the CPN (Maoist Centre), said that the coalition had always sought an agreement between the ruling and opposition parties for the smooth functioning of the parliament and to advance the remaining tasks of the peace process. Additionally, he said that the ruling parties had opened up towards the opposition parties in the formation of the parliament few months ago.

He said, "Usually, the opposition parties get to lead only one Public Accounts Committee. But this time, we agreed to give the leadership of three committees to the CPN-UML. However, this doesn't mean undermining the coalition in any way." He said that there should be no doubt about coalition's stability as it was not formed out of minor struggles. He stressed that the coalition was formed for the protection of the constitution and the House of Representatives and everyone involved should work together to make it last till the end.

> Stating that some forces were raising questions against federal democratic republic, Prime Minister Prachanda assured that such a situation did not exist.

Stating that some forces were raising questions against federal democratic republic, Prime Minister Prachanda assured that such a situation did not exist. He claimed that within a year, the government had achieved several national and international records. He said, "For the first time in Nepal's history, laws have been enacted to liberate millions of poor farmers, especially in the Tarai and Madhes, who were victims of loan sharks." He said that the government had made significant improvements in Nepal's economic situation within a year.

He said that when he assumed office there were many questions like Nepal was about to fail, had bad economic situation and would be trapped in a major crisis. He said, "However, when I assume the office a year ago, we had the foreign currency reserve sufficient for only three months, now we have enough reserve for 13 months "

Shah assures equal distribution of resources

BY GOKARNA DAYAL
Baitadi, Jan. 4

Sudurpashchim Province Chief Minister Kamal Bahadur Shah has said that resources will be distributed equally across all local levels of the district. He said so while arriving in Baitadi for the inspection of the development projects on Thursday.

During the visit, Chief Minister Shah said that he would visit all nine districts of the province and meet local representatives, officials and journalists.

Speaking at the press meet organised in Gothalapani on Thursday, Chief Minister Shah informed that in the first phase, he visited Darchula, Baitadi and Dadeldhura to get updates about the state of development projects carried out in the province. He said," The provincial government is reaching out to districts to directly engage with its citizens. After inspecting the hilly districts, we will visit Kailali and Kanchanpur districts at the end."

He said that the provincial government had allocated more than Rs. 1 billion for fiscal equalisation to the local levels within a year while previous provincial governments had provided the same amount of money over five years.

He said, "While allocating the budget, we requested plans from wards, local levels and provincial election constituencies. We are now monitoring whether the plans have been completed on time or not."

Chief Minister Shah said that the provincial government was reconsidering whether to continue or remove projects that fail to be completed on time. He also informed about his Darchula visit and said that he prioritised Darchula over Baitadi as some local levels in Darchula were still inaccessible by road.

At the press meet, journalists drew the attention of the Chief Minister over the lack of quality healthcare services in the district. They pointed out the disparity in the budget allocation for purchasing medicines. They said that despite the allocation of Rs. 2 million to the local level for the purchase of medicines only Rs. 1 million was sent to the hospital.

Meanwhile, Chief Minister Shah said that the provincial government was committed to upgrading district hospitals, managing skilled manpower and prioritising projects like the West Seti Project and the Patan-Pancheshwor road project.

Indian Minister calls on President, PM

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan . 4

Indian External Affairs Minister Dr. S. Jaishankar paid a courtesy call on President Ramchandra Paudel at the latter's office in Sheetal Niwas.

Spokesperson of the President's Office Shailaja Regmi Bhattarai informed in a statement that during the meeting the President emphasised on paying serious attention to the impacts of climate change in Nepal and the world and taking a collective initiative to protect the Himalayas and environment.

President Paudel and Dr. Jaishankar talked about the bilateral relations between the two countries, mutual interests and common concerns. The President also said that the connections between the two countries were based on natural, cultural and religious heritages so they should be mobilised and protected for the greater benefit of the people of Nepal and India.

Dr. Jaishankar also called on Prime Minister Prachanda at his residence in Baluwatar where the two discussed about the possible economic and other cooperation in future.

The visiting Minister of India said in X that PM Prachanda recalled his successful visit to

» SEE PAGE 6

Police HQ sends new DSP in Lalitpur after Balkumari incident

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 4

In replacement of suspended Deputy Superintendent of Police (DSP) Umesh Lamsal, the Police Headquarters, Naxal, has sent DSP Sudhir Rai to the District Police Range, Lalitpur.

DSP Umesh Lamsal, working in Lalitpur Police Range, has been suspended after two youths were killed in firing during the protest at the EPS office in Balkumari last Friday. Lamsal was suspended a day after the deaths of Sujan Rawat of Dailekh and Birendra Shah of Achham.

According to Deputy Inspector General (DIG) and the Central Spokesperson for the Police Headquarters, Kuber Kadayat, DSP Rai was sent in place of DSP Lamsal.

EPS office chief Guru Dutta Subedi, DSP Lamsal and Physical Infrastructure and Transport Minister Prakash Jwala's PSO Police Assistant Inspector (ASI) Bodhraj Danuwar were suspended following the incident. No one has been sent to the EPS office yet. The Headquarters has also not sent a police chief for the District Police Range, Lalitpur after SSP Siddi Bikram Shah has been pulled from his duties to the Headquarters.

Further, the Home Ministry has not yet sent new Chief District Officer in Lalitpur after pulling Rudra Prasad Pandit to the Ministry.

The Ministry of Labour, Employment and Social Security has also not transferred anyone to replace Subedi.

Today's Supplement

Highlight

Innovate education can transform Nepal



Nepal set to make millions through carbon trade

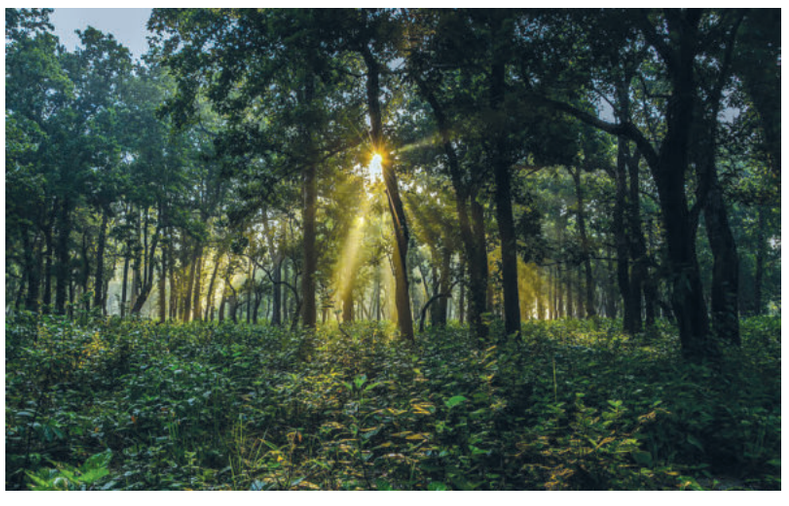
BY INDIRA ARYAL
Kathmandu, Jan. 4

They say that money does not grow on trees, but Nepal is proving it wrong as it is poised to make significant financial gains through its forests.

From its forests of 13 Tarai districts from Rautahat to Kanchanpur, Nepal is going to receive around US$ 10 to 11 million within six months, the first payment from selling carbon credits from trees, commonly called carbon trade, said Yagyamurti, Under Secretary at REDD+ Implementation Centre of the Ministry of Forest and Environment.

Carbon trade from trees is a way for companies and countries to balance their carbon emissions by planting and managing trees. It is like they earn points for reducing pollution, and if they have extra points, they can sell more carbon emitters and receive money out of it.

Under the Carbon Trade Agreement inked between the government of Nepal and the World Bank on February 24, 2021, the Emission Reduction Plan Document (ERPD) is being achieved over a span of six years from 2018 to 2024 in 13



districts of Tarai Arc Landscape (TAL). The implementation of ERPD aims to curb 9 million tonnes of carbon dioxide emissions in the Tarai Arc Landscape. As per the agreement, the government submitted its initial Emission Reduction (ER) monitoring report to the World Bank.

This arrangement launches two reporting periods for performance-based payments, highlighting the commitment to sustainable forest management and emission reduction goals in Nepal.

According to Khanal, the WB has passed on the report and sent it to a third party for verification. "We have been conducting online meetings with the third party, they may visit the field for measurements before giving us a certificate. Once the report is verified, we will obtain a certificate from the third party. The certificate is the means to receive funds. We have a six-month window to secure the first instalment from our forest," he said.

On June 22, 2018, the government started a programme called "People and Forests - A Sustainable Forest Management-Based Emission Reduction Programme in the Tarai Arc Landscape". After giving a plan called ERPD to the Forest Carbon Partnership Facility (FCPF) on May 23, 2018, Nepal's plan was accepted in a meeting in Paris on June 20-22, 2018, and is now part of the Carbon Fund Portfolio.

"The programme is a mirror of how much the country cares about fighting climate change and adopting eco-friendly measures. Teaming up with the World Bank, Nepal is working to make its future greener and more environmentally friendly," Khanal added.

Tarai districts were chosen because the forests in the region play a crucial role in climate resilience by providing essential ecosystem services, including watershed protection and mitigating droughts and floods. It will safeguard forests inseparably connected to the well-being of numerous communities in the region and across the country, he said.

» SEE PAGE 6

Gold price declines by Rs. 1,300 per tola

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 4



The prices of gold and silver have decreased noticeably on Thursday.

The price of gold has dropped by Rs. 1,300 per tola in the domestic market Thursday as compared to Wednesday's price.

According to the Federation of Nepal Gold and Silver Dealers' Association (FENEGOSIDA), the price of gold decreased to Rs. 119,500 per tola (11.664 grams) today compared to Rs. 120,800 of Wednesday.

Likewise, the price of silver has also decreased by Rs. 30 per tola to Rs. 1,420

Earlier on December 28, price of gold had reached Rs. 122,000 per tola in the local market.

The price of gold has decreased sharply on Thursday in the local market due to decrease in its price in the international market, said Tej Ratna Shakya, gold trader and special member of the FENEGOSIDA.

According to him, the price of gold has come down as investors have been attracted to the dollar and the pressure to sell gold has started.

"Selling pressure of gold has led to a drop in its price in the international market as the international investors are encouraged to sell gold by securing profit," he said.

Fluctuation in the international market price have its impact on the domestic bullion market as well, he said.

Gold price in the international market has decreased by US$ 21 per ounce to US$ 2,044 today, he said. Price of gold was USD 2,065 per ounce in the international market on Wednesday.

Due to price hikes of gold in the market over the months, demand for gold has remained low in the local market.

GAS AND FERTILIZER FROM SOLID WASTE IN BIRENDRANAGAR

RSS
Bheriganga (Surkhet), Jan. 4

Solid waste has been used to produce gas and organic fertilizer in Birendranagar.

This is the first of its kind in Karnali, which is being carried with personal investment. Krishna Prasad Dhakal, a youth from Birendranagar municipality-11 has started converting solid waste into gas and fertilizer.

For the purpose, Dhakal has set up a gas plant using German technology with an investment of Rs 140 million. Of the amount, 50 million has been supported by the World Bank.

Currently, garbage from vegetable market and shops are now being collected. Dhakal plans to collect the solid waste from every household in the municipality.

The gas industry plant is currently producing 720 quintals of gas and nine tons of organic fertilizer every day. Gas produced from the plant can be used for cooking as well as for running gas-run vehicles, Dhakal said.

Currently, 19 people have been directly employed in the industry that sells gas at Rs 140 kg per kg and fertilizer at Rs 25 per kg.

Businesses call for solution to dedicated line dispute

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 4

The Chamber of Industries Morang (CIM), Morang Merchant Association (MMA) and Confederation of Nepalese Industries, Koshi Province have demanded to resolve the problems of dedicated and trunk line by reconnecting power supply lines of those industries whose line has been cut at the earliest.

Issuing a joint press statement, CIM, MMA and CNI Koshi Province urged for resolving the issues of dedicated and trunk lines arrears in coordination with the tripartite stakeholders—government, Nepal Electricity Authority (NEA) and private sector - immediately as the private sector also feels justice.

"Regarding the issue of dedicated and trunk line electricity tariffs, which has been disputed for a long time, our attention has been drawn to the fact that the NEA has cut the power supply so that the production of industries has stopped. We strongly request the government and all stakeholders to take concrete steps," read the press statement.

They have demanded that a just solution should be found to this matter which has become complicated due to their respective positions and the tussle between the Nepal Electricity Authority and the affected industrialists for a long time regarding the dedicated and trunk line electricity tariffs.

The NEA cut electricity supplies of 23 industries getting power supply from dedicated feeder and trunk lines.

According to the Authority, 61 industries have to settle Rs. 22.24 billion in arrears.

Stating that negative message has been sent to the domestic and international arena after the NEA cut power supply of industries, it said that the government should take immediate steps for a just solution even though the industrial factories have been closed till now and the production is affected.

BEST FARMERS OF NUWAKOT AND RASUWA FELICITATED

RSS
Trishuli (Nuwakot), Jan. 4

The best six farmers of Nuwakot and Rasuwa districts have been honoured with cash prize. They were felicitated by the 'President's Best Farmer Award' program.

The Agricultural Knowledge Center Nuwakot, that oversees the two districts, honoured the three farmers selected as the best farmers from the two districts on Wednesday with a cash prize of Rs. 20,000 each.

The best farmers from Nuwakot are Tilkumari Neupane, a buffalo farmer from Bidur municipality-5, Dhankumari Gurung, a goat breeder from Shivapuri Rural Municipality-1 and strawberry farmer Astlal Tamang from Kakani Rural Municipality-2. Similarly, the best farmers from Rasuwa are Gyal Dorje Tamang, an apple farmer from Gosainkunda Rural Municipality-6 in Rasuwa, Heer Bahadur Tamang, an apple farmer and animal breeder from Uttargaya Rural Municipality-2, and Pemba Tamang, a vegetable farmer from Naukunda Rural Municipality-6.

On the occasion, Chief of Agriculture Knowledge Centre, Keshav Khanal, said the awardees could become model for other youths to do something in their own country.

Meanwhile, the best farmers selected from Nuwakot and Rasuwa districts have been recommended by Agriculture Knowledge Center for Bagmati province level best farmer awards.

'Germany's CO2 emissions are at their lowest in 7 decades'

AP
Berlin, Jan. 4

Carbon dioxide emissions in Germany, Europe's biggest economy, dropped to their lowest level in seven decades as the use of coal declined unexpectedly sharply in 2023 and economic pressures weighed down production by energy-intensive industry, according to a study released Thursday.

Germany aims to cut its emissions to net zero by 2045 and is working to ramp up the use of solar and wind power and other renewable sources.

The Agora Energiewende think tank said its preliminary calculations show that Germany emitted 673 million metric tons of CO2 last year, a decline of 73 million metric tons compared with 2022 and the lowest level since the 1950s. The figure was 46% below the country's emissions in 1990.

On Tuesday, Germany's Federal Network Agency said that renewable energy sources accounted for more than half of the country's energy production in 2023. Renewables rose to 56% of energy production, from 47.4% in 2022. At the same time, electricity production using black coal dropped to 8.9% from 12.8%, and lignite-fired electricity declined to 17.4% from 21%.

Germany switched off its last three nuclear power plants in April — a long-planned move, though some argued for a rethink after energy prices spiked because of the war in Ukraine. Nuclear power accounted for 1.5% of energy production in 2023, down from 6.7% the previous year.



PHOTO: AP

Steam rises from the coal-fired power plant in Neurath, Germany, on June 8, 2023.

More than half of last year's reduction in emissions — some 44 million metric tons — was down to coal-fired electricity production falling to its lowest level since the 1960s, Agora said. That in turn was caused by a drop in electricity demand and increased imports from neighboring countries, around half of which came from renewable energy sources.

Also, emissions from industry declined considerably as energy-intensive companies reduced production as a result of economic weakness and international crises, the think tank said.

Germany, the worst-performing major developed economy in recent months, has been weighed down by high energy prices, global economic weakness and interest rate hikes to fight inflation. The country is home to many energy-intensive companies, including in the chemical and metal industries.

Agora calculated that only about 15% of last year's emissions savings constitute "permanent emissions reductions resulting from additional renewable energy capacity, efficiency gains and the switch to fuels that produce less CO2 or other climate friendly alternatives." It said that "most of the emissions cuts in 2023 are not sustainable from an industrial or climate policy perspective."

Economy and Climate Minister Robert Habeck, a member of the environmentalist Green party who is also vice chancellor, said Germany has laid the foundations for future growth in renewable energy by moving to expand solar and wind generation.

"We are making visible progress on the road to climate-neutral electricity supply," he said.

As for industry, "it is good that investments are being made in climate production and energy efficiency," he said in a statement. But "it isn't good that Russia's war of aggression on Ukraine and the price crisis that (Russian President Vladimir) Putin wanted are leading to declines in production."

Habeck pointed to government efforts to reduce electricity prices for industry.

Biden administration announces $162 million to expand computer chip factories

AP
Washington, Jan. 4

The Biden administration is providing $162 million to Microchip Technology to support the domestic production of computer chips — the second funding announcement tied to a 2022 law designed to revive U.S. semiconductor manufacturing.

The incentives include $90 million to improve a plant in Colorado Springs, Colorado, and $72 million to expand a factory in Gresham, Oregon, the Commerce Department said.

The investments would enable Microchip Technology to triple its domestic production and reduce its dependence on foreign factories.

Much of the money would fund the making of microcontrollers, which are used by the military as well as in autos, household appliances and medical devices. Government officials said they expected the investments to create 700 construction and manufacturing jobs over the next decade.

Lael Brainard, director of the White House National Economic Council, emphasized that the funding would help to tame inflation.

"Semiconductors are the key input in so many goods that are vital to our economy," said Brainard, adding that greater U.S. production of chips would have reduced the supply problems that caused the cost of autos and washing machines, among other goods, to rise as the country emerged from the coronavirus pandemic in 2021.

The inflation rate has since eased, but the scars caused by the sudden price increases have damaged President Joe Biden's public approval.

In August 2022, Biden signed the bipartisan CHIPS and Science Act, which provides more than $52 billion to boost the development and manufacturing of semiconductors in the United States.

In December, the Commerce Department announced the first grants by saying it reached an agreement to provide $35 million to BAE Systems, which plans to expand a New Hampshire factory making chips for military aircraft, including F-15 and F-35 jets.

Government officials expect to make additional funding commitments this year.



PHOTO: AP

President Joe Biden speaks about his economic agenda at the Wisconsin Black Chamber of Commerce, Wednesday, Dec. 20, 2023, in Milwaukee.

Lumbini Chamber of Commerce signs MoU with different international chamber chapters

RSS
Lumbini, Jan. 4

Representatives of Hindu Chamber of Commerce, Canada, and Federation of Canada-Nepal Chamber of Commerce, who arrived in Lumbini on Wednesday in course of Nepal visit, and representative of Lumbini Chamber of Commerce signed the MoU.

Lumbini Province Chamber of Commerce has made agreement for partnership and collaboration with different international chamber chapters.

President of Lumbini Chamber of Commerce, Tanka Prasad Pokharel, shared that a memorandum of understanding has been signed for partnership among Nepal Chamber of Commerce, Hong Kong; Hindu Chamber of Commerce, Canada and Federation of Canada-Nepal Chamber of Commerce.

Representatives of Hindu Chamber of Commerce, Canada, and Federation of Canada-Nepal Chamber of Commerce, who arrived in Lumbini on Wednesday in course of Nepal visit, and representative of Lumbini Chamber of Commerce signed the MoU.

President Pokharel on the behalf of Lumbini Chamber, President Bijay Poudel on the behalf of Federation of Canada Nepal Chamber of Commerce and President Naresh Chawada on the behalf of Hindu Chamber of Commerce, Canada, signed the MoU.

Earlier in last December, President Pokharel had signed agreement with representatives of Nepal Chamber of Commerce, Hong Kong.

An understanding was reached with the three chambers to collaborate with each other, making efforts for Lumbini Chamber's participation in international forum, regularly organising training, discussion, seminar and interaction, exchanging experiences and exchange of business visits.

Similarly, an agreement was reached to support for the promotion of commercial opportunities in Lumbini Province.

'We need to link education with the labour market'

Aathabis Municipality is the second-largest municipality in Dailekh district, formed in 2015 by merging the erstwhile village development committees of Satala, Sigaudi, Ramkarnali, Pipalkot, Sihasain and Tilepata. Rakam Karnali in Ward No. 4 has been fixed as the centre of this municipality because it is part of the new cities project under the Mid Hill Highway, is easily accessible from the Karnali Highway and has good topography.

Tarka Bahadur Baduwal of the CPN-UML party was elected the mayor in the 2022 local election. *The Rising Nepal*'s Dailekh correspondent **Kamal Sharma** interviewed Baduwal and talked about the work he accomplished in the past one and a half years after he was elected to the post.



PHOTO: KAMAL SHARMA/TRN

Tarka Bahadur Baduwal, Mayor of Aathabis Municipality in Dailekh district.

How have you found your time in the office so far?

After the people trusted me and elected me the mayor, I tried to implement the programmes we had promised in our manifesto. Before my election, the municipality had over Rs. 90 million in arrears. This had made it difficult for the local level to even pay its employees.

Overall, I am satisfied with the past one and a half years as I have been able to do some work and have received support from all quarters of society.

The municipality does have Rs. 97.1 million in arrears. How did that happen?

In the fiscal year 2020/21, the municipality forwarded Rs. 41.6 million in payments for various projects, but it failed to report that amount through the proper system. Similarly, the local government was required to send back the Rs. 45.6 million that it could not spend that fiscal year. However, it chose to keep that amount and spend it in the fiscal year 2021/22. Both these amounts got reported as arrears.

What are you planning to do about such a huge arrear amount?

This huge arrear amount has prevented us from implementing our plans. It would be easier if the Rs. 41.6 million we used for payments and the Rs. 45.6 million we spent a fiscal year later are not considered arrears. But the federal government has not heeded our calls, forcing us to pay Rs. 25 million every fiscal year and use only what's left for Aathabis's development.

Do you plan to do anything to improve the quality of education in local schools?

First of all, rather than improving quality of education, I see the need to link education to the labour market. In fact, I would say that our educational quality is poor because our curricula do not reflect local values, is not based on local resources and do not relate to the needs of the market. Quality education is an education that is practical and prepares students for jobs.

Lack of policies, foresight, coordination and curriculum development framework, as well as weak administration and political interference also prevent us from lifting our educational standards. The federal government should take steps to address these issues and keep Nepali students inside Nepal.

How is the construction of the basic hospital moving forward?

The basic hospital, being built under the 'One local level, one basic hospital' campaign launched by the then Prime Minister KP Sharma Oli, is almost complete. In fact, 90 per cent of the work is already done.

Three important projects – Mid Hill (Pushpalal Highway), Upper Karnali Hydropower Project and Karnali New City Project – are being implemented in your municipality. But their progress is not satisfactory. How do you plan to change that?

The Mid Hill Highway passes through Ward Nos. 1 and 2 of our municipality. This project is moving forward smoothly. The road remains to be blacktopped in some places but that will be completed within this fiscal year.

INTERVIEW

The Upper Karnali project lies within the jurisdiction of the federal government. Nevertheless, we have contacted the relevant person from the project and asked them to expedite the work. We have also asked the provincial government to hold discussions with the federal government to help the project pick up pace.

Regarding the new city project, Rakam Karnali is one of 10 new cities to be developed across the country. Compensation disputes that were present before the formation of the local government have largely been solved and many parts of the project are being implemented.

We also have the Karnali Highway here. The necessary bridges have not been constructed, which is causing great difficulty for our residents. But, unfortunately, the municipality cannot legally do anything in this regard.

Chhaupadi is rampant in your municipality. What do you need to do to end this social evil?

Chhaupadi is a problem prevalent all over Karnali and Sudurpashchim provinces. Under the federal government's leadership, a campaign to demolish the Chhau huts lasted for some time, but after it ended, people started building them again. So, we now feel that the solution is not the demolition of Chhau huts but to educate people about safe menstruation. We are telling people that even if they choose to separate women during their period, have them stay in safe places. Chhaupadi will not end anytime soon but things are slowly changing.

How is the local government coordinating with the federal and provincial levels?

The principles of cooperation and co-existence outlined by the Constitution have not been followed. In our Karnali Province, the budget is spent as per whims and fancies of the leaders without properly navigating the actual needs of the people. Budget is not allocated proportionally and based on needs, which has made it difficult for us to execute all our plans.

Mountain birds migrate to plains to escape cold



PHOTO: BIJAYA KUMAR SAH/TRN

The migratory birds from the Himalayan region have begun arriving at Dhanushdham in Dhanusha.

BIJAYA KUMAR SAH
Dhalkebar, Jan. 4

Birds from the Himalayan region are beginning to spend the winter in the safe habitat of the protected forest areas, rivers and wetlands of Dhanushdham in Dhanusha.

Ganesh Sah, an employee at the protected forest area, mentioned that the arrival of birds began in December, and they will continue to migrate till the second or third week of January.

Sah informed that about half a dozen species of birds have arrived in the area so far. "The forest area boasts of abundant food, a secure habitat, an expansive eight-bigha lake, and numerous small wetlands, creating a safe and inviting environment for the visiting birds," he added.

Highlighting the annual migration pattern, Sah mentioned that Himalayan birds arrive consistently during the cold season; out of the 888 bird species in Nepal, 282 are found in this forest area.

Birds like Kalo Garudh (Black Stork), Seto Garudh (White Stork), and Khoya hans (bar-headed Goose) are spotted in grassland and wetland of Tarai, said Sah.

Dev Narayan Mandal, the president of Mithila Wildlife Trust, Dhanusha, said that Himalayan birds frequently visit Dhanushdham protected forest area and Kamala River and Janakpurdham.

Mandal pointed out the numerous reservoirs in Janakpurdham and the continuous flow of water in the Kamala River, has attracted mountain birds.

The migration of birds to Tarai is likely to intensify after it starts snowing in mountainous region.

These birds return to their habitat in Himalayan region along with their offspring in February after they hatch their eggs.

CHILD MARRIAGE PRACTICE FOUND COMMON IN KARNALI

BY OUR CORRESPONDENT
Surkhet, Jan. 4

As per a report, of the total pregnant women in Karnali Province, 21 per cent were aged below 19 years.

According to the data presented by the Nepal Demographic Health Survey, 2022, Jajarkot district has the highest number of pregnant teenage girls at 38.83 per cent while Kalikot has the lowest number of pregnant girls at 20.20 per cent.

Similarly, child marriage was found most common in the Dalit communities, especially among the people of the Badi community.

Chetan Giri, a human rights activist working in the field of children's rights, informed that alongside Dalits, the practice of child marriage practice was common among the Brahmins, Chhetris and other tribal groups in the province.

"The situation of child marriage is becoming worrisome because the provincial and local governments have not introduced any concrete programmes to control the evil practice," said Giri.

The main reason for the prevalence of child marriage is the lack of effective implementation of the laws by government agencies.

Human rights activists said that incidents of child marriage are increasing because government agencies are unable to register complaints about child marriage, conduct necessary investigations and prosecute and punish the culprits.

Lack of a child-friendly environment, illiteracy, and the negative effects of social media leads to child marriage.

Similarly, child marriage is a leading cause of surge in maternal and infant mortality rates, family conflict, divorce, polygamy and even suicide.

The Daughters' Bank Accounts for Lifetime Protection programme introduced two years ago has not come into effect due to budget constraints.

87 % of target population receives anti-typhoid jabs in Kalikot

BY PREMRAJ SIMKHADA
Kalikot Jan. 4

Around 87 per cent of citizens in Kalikot district have received vaccination against typhoid. Citizens from the age group of 18 to 45 years participated in the vaccination programme, which was conducted at all nine local levels of the district from December 28 to January 3. Altogether 49,906 people have been vaccinated in the district.

This is 86.82 per cent of the total target group. The number of women receiving vaccination is 29,222 while 20,684 men got the jabs.

Raskot Municipality has administered the highest number of typhoid vaccinations among the nine local levels. In Raskot, 7,481 people were vaccinated which is 98.57 per cent targeted population.

Shankar Prasad Baral, Senior Auxiliary Health Worker, said that citizens were interested in typhoid vaccination. He said that the people were encouraged to receive the vaccine against typhoid giving it importance like the coronavirus vaccine.

Citizens of Mahawai Rural Municipality have also been vaccinated. The data showed that 98.4 per cent of the people in the target age group were vaccinated in Mahawai.

Sanket Bishwakarma, Managing Director of the Health Service Office, Kalikot, said that the largest number of locals from Raskot, Mahawai and Tilagufa municipalities received the vaccines in the district.

In Tilagufa Municipality, 92.80 per cent of the residents have been vaccinated. The target of the Health Service Office Kalikot was to vaccinate 60,000 citizens. However, the target has not been met as many locals are out of the district in search of employment.

Lanka Bahadur Bam, Statistics Officer of the Health Service Office, Kalikot, said that the target could not be met because many men from the district go to India for work.

Bam informed that most people also go to the city areas for higher education and employment. Around 10,000 people have not been vaccinated against typhoid in Kalikot.

The vaccination against typhoid is mostly concentrated in the districts affected by the earthquake as well as 10 districts of Karnali and Sudurpashchim Provinces.

According to health experts, after receiving the vaccine against typhoid, one will not be infected with typhoid.

PRO-IDENTITY GROUP LIFTS STRIKE ON VEHICULAR MOVEMENTS

BY OUR CORRESPONDENT
Pashupatinagar (Ilam), Jan. 4

The strike imposed by the pro-identity group on vehicular movements along the Mechi Highway has been withdrawn.

Vehicular movement resumed along the Mechi Highway which remained shut from Wednesday after the court ordered to release pro-identity group leader Bullet Kirati on bail.

The district court has ordered to release of Kirati on a bail of Rs. 200,000.

The bandh has been lifted from 2: 00 pm Thursday. After the release Kirati was ensured, the Province No. 1 Re-naming Committee withdrew the bandh issuing a notice.

Province No. 1 Chairman of the Re-naming Committee, Devendra Singh Thegim, said that the government should make arrangements for proper compensation, including treatment of mutilations and injuries in different programmes.

The police informed that Kirati would be released after the bail amount was deposited.

A large number of domestic tourists were stranded because of the highway closure.

Auditing Standards Board
(Formed by Government of Nepal under the Nepal Chartered Accountants Act, 2053)
Building of the Institute of Chartered Accountants of Nepal, Satdobato, Lalitpur
Tel No. : 01-5539437, Website : www.ausb.gov.np
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Notice Regarding Publication of Exposure Draft of "Nepal Standards on Auditing–2024"

First Time Publication: January 5, 2024 (2080/09/20 BS)

The Auditing Standards Board (AuSB) has developed an Exposure Draft of **"Nepal Standards on Auditing – 2024"** in line with the "2021 Handbook of International Quality Control, Auditing, Review, Other Assurance, And Related Services Pronouncements" published by International Auditing and Assurance Standards Board (IAASB). Exposure Draft Standards are available in the website of Auditing Standards Board of Nepal (www.ausb.gov.np).

This notice has been published in order to obtain comments and suggestions on Exposure Draft Standards. AuSB requests to submit comments and suggestions through the AuSB's website, email or post by 07th Falgun, 2080 (19th February, 2024).

Board Secretariat
लेखापरीक्षणमान बोर्ड
AUDITING STANDARDS BOARD

Humla students take exams basking in sun

BY OUR CORRESPONDENT
Humla, Jan 4.

School students in the northern part of Humla district are happy when they are allowed to take their examinations in the open basking in the sun. They have got the opportunity at a time when they have been unable even to play inside their classroom because of the dipping mercury in the district.

"It has become easier to write examinations sitting outdoors in the sunlight. It is freezing inside the classroom during the winter and many friends were facing difficulty writing answers," said Shrijana Shahi, a student at the Balbhadra Basic School of Simkot Rural Municipality -8



PHOTO: RAJAN RAWAT/TRN

The students of the Balbhadra Basic School are taking part in the examination in the open at Simkot Rural Municipality -8 in Humla.

Prem Kala Buda, headteacher of the school, informed that the school management decided to take the examination in the open field as it was extremely cold in the classroom. " A total of 150 students from grades four to six are taking the exams outside the school buildings. Desk and chairs are also provided to the children to write the exams," added Buda.

Similarly, Dev Bahadur Buda, Headmaster of Saipal Middle School, informed that 300 students from grades four to 10 are taking examinations in the open field because of the freezing temperature.

Nepal Electricity Authority
Distribution and Consumer Services Directorate
Durbar Marga, Kathmandu, Nepal

Notification of Intent to Award the Contract
(Date of Publication: 5 January 2024)

Pursuant to Clause 43 of Instructions to Bidders of bidding document, the concerned bidders are notified that the Nepal Electricity Authority intends to award the contract to the lowest evaluated substantially responsive bidder as mentioned below:

S. N.	IFB No. and Title	Lowest Evaluated Substantially Responsive Bidder	Amount
1	ICB/DCSD-079/80-24: Supply and Delivery of Hardware and Accessories of Medium Voltage Covered Conductor	Sicame India Connectors Pvt Ltd, India	USD 1,906,350.00 (Excluding Custom and VAT)
2	ICB/DCSD-079/80-25: Supply and Delivery of Hardware and Accessories of Low Voltage Aerial Bunched Cable	Sicame India Connectors Pvt Ltd, India	USD 1,714,400.00 (Excluding Custom and VAT)

THOUGHT FOR TODAY

Try to be a rainbow in someone else's cloud.

-- Maya Angelou

EDITORIAL

Reconstruction Urgency

Two months into the November 3 earthquake, by now all those who were left homeless should have been rehabilitated in decent houses strong enough to provide shelter from the elements. But in a heart-wrenching scene, many victims – several of whom are elderlies, newborns, expectant mothers and others – in the worst affected districts of Jajarkot and West Rukum continue to languish in tents in the middle of biting winter cold. The reason: delay in the construction of temporary houses. And the more delay it gets, the more things will turn from bad to worse.

Aware of this reality and intent on addressing the issue, Prime Minister Pushpa Kamal Dahal Prachanda has said that the National Disaster Risk Reduction and Management Authority (NDRRMA) would be given all the responsibility of the reconstruction works of private and government infrastructure damaged by the quake. He acknowledged that the state's mechanism is deeply rooted and based on completing many formalities rather than delivering result-oriented works in swift way to any kind of disaster victims. We have taken this as a positive sign. But to bring about radical change, first we must identify the problem.

We are shocked to learn the victims have yet to get the money the government pledged – Rs. 50,000 – to make available as a relief to each victim in the immediate aftermath of the quake for the construction of temporary shelters. The Prime Minister attributed this problem to the procedural arrangements made in the Act, regulation and policies and has vowed to remove this hassle within his term. The government is said to have arranged Rs. 10 billion for the victims. However, the NDRRMA estimates the reconstruction could cost at Rs. 70-75 billion in the two quake-hit provinces of Karnali and Sudurpaschim.

As things stand, recovery effort is far from satisfactory. Minister for Finance Dr. Prakash Sharan Mahat's pledge that there won't be a situation of non-availability of budget for the reconstruction has raised hope but arranging that big amount is surely a herculean task. The minister should make it clear how he is going to bridge the budget shortfall. Without donor agencies stepping in, that would, of course, remain a far-fetched dream, and to prod them to support our effort, we must first be able to pour the earmarked money into reconstruction effort, and fast enough.

We hope reinvigorating the NDRRMA will be a game changer. There's no doubt that its long experience in rebuilding hundreds of thousands of houses levelled by the 2015 mega earthquake in a host of districts, including Gorkha, Dhading, Sindhupalchowk, Kathmandu, Kavre, among many others, is an invaluable asset, and we must be able to harness it to the fullest to repeat its glory. The delay has already taken a devastating toll on the victims. That said, we must give credit where it's due: In Rukum West, the government has succeeded in constructing 7,079 houses while the construction of another 9,341 houses is in progress. The situation is similar in Jajarkot. Why can't we fast-track work even when it's a matter of life and death? Unless we get rid of the bureaucratic hassles that prevent the work from getting done, the efforts to give urgent delivery to the disaster victims will remain a far cry.

Opt For Quake Preparedness

BINI DAHAL

On 1st of January, 2024, Japan was hit with a massive earthquake measuring 7.6 magnitude on the Richter scale. The disaster happened on Noto peninsula of Ishikawa prefecture. Earthquakes generally occur because of the movement of tectonic plates. This East Asian nation is situated among four tectonic plates.

News reports have it that Japan is one of such countries where 18 per cent of earthquakes happen all because of the overly active plates. Not just earthquakes, Japan is highly prone to volcanoes and tsunamis as well. The country is part of the Ring of Fire which comprises fifteen nations.

As this article is being written, the number of casualties has reached sixty-two. It is said that more than 100 buildings and 1,000 homes of the people have been destroyed. The Japanese government has also warned of aftershocks and possible incidents of landslides. This incident that took place at the start of New Year is very painful. However, Japan is known for its earthquake-resilient buildings and its technologies.

So, as compared to other countries, the casualties are comparatively low. The country mainly makes use of three kinds of structures namely: Taishin, Seishin and Menshin structures.

The Taishin structure is the basic one that every building should follow. It is mainly concerned with building thick pillars, walls and beams so as to absorb the shaking.

In the case of Seishin structure, thick rubber pads or mats are used in the foundation of a building, especially a high rise one. And the Menshin structure focusses on using lead, steel and thick layers of rubber on the base of the building to minimise the force of earthquake on upper frames of the building. These types of earthquake resilient designs really help prevent large casualties and damage of properties from happening.

Like in Japan, earthquakes are a frequent occurrence in Nepal, too. The Himalayan nation stands on the boundary of two tectonic plates namely Indian and Eurasian plates.

Our building construction system is in question considering the huge damage caused by the mega earthquake of 2015, and the recent one in the far-western region. It is a known fact that we do not have earthquake-resilient buildings. Even the existing building codes are not stringent enough to protect us.

In urban centres like Kathmandu, the demand for accommodating more and more people has forced people to build high-rise buildings, without any care of what possibly an earthquake can cause. People are found defying the building codes and a lack of monitoring mechanism from the side of the authority makes it all the more difficult. Our memory is quite short-lived. The discussion stretches as long as the earthquake and its tremors are felt.

It is limited to knowing the state of destruction caused to properties and suffering to people and nothing more. Incorporating earthquake-resilient designs is an expensive move and without strict push from the government and with people's own awareness, nothing can happen. Japan's resilient buildings are a motivation for countries around the world to head towards such designs.

While it is impossible to stop earthquake tremors, the least we can do is be prepared for what comes ahead. It is high time the countries learnt a lesson and took necessary actions. Where there is a will, there is a way should be the kind of attitude that earthquake and other disaster-prone nations should take up.

Accountability For Good Governance

Lok Deep Thapa



There seems to be much differences between the political parties, even those who are partners in the present coalition government. First of all, the largest party in the present coalition, the Nepali Congress, is itself divided in several factions and in the just concluded Central Committee meeting of the party, many leaders expressed their unhappiness at the performance of their own ministers. Prime Minister Pushpa Kamal Dahal also has repeatedly said that he was not satisfied with the work of certain ministers and bureaucrats and he would change them for making the government more efficient and effective in the coming year. This has given a much-needed boost to the morale of the common citizens as they believe that the Prime Minister seems really serious in delivering goods to the common people.

However there are detractors as well in criticising the performance of the government. And this includes members of the coalition partners in the present government itself. The Nepali Congress organised its routine annual function of the 'National Reconciliation Day' just a few days back and here also it bypassed some parties and gave the feeling that it was not really serious about political reconciliation. One analyst said in a discussion programme that 'when the Nepali Congress cannot bring reconciliation in the party itself, how can it bring in national reconciliation?' This is a good question, but the fact remains that the leaders of this party are still trying to maintain the ideals of its founder, late BP Koirala, who first introduced the idea of national reconciliation. His own younger brother late Girija Prasad Koirala could not keep intact the ideals and farsightedness of his brother.

Grievances

But to come back to the efforts of the present Prime Minister Dahal, he has shown the way by cutting down the number of employees in the Prime Minister's Office itself. This is a good beginning. It was also reported in the media that Dahal reaches his office by 10 A.M. every day, except on public holidays. This is an improvement from the time when late Girija and late Sushil Koirala ran the nation from their rooms in Baluwatar when they were the prime ministers. There is no doubt the government has seen a lot of ups and downs in the past one year, but like said by PM Dahal, he himself is not satisfied with the works in certain ministries and he would act soon to remedy the past mistakes. There have been protests in many sectors and we have been witness to many such protests from industrialists and entrepreneurs to students and youths who seek to go abroad.

The last episode which shook the government was when two youngsters wanting to go to South Korea for employment were killed in a demonstration at Balkumari of Lalitpur district. But the government acted quickly and has made efforts to provide relief to the families of the two and also release those arrested during the demonstration. That the vehicle of one minister was burned down is not a good indicator of coordination between the security agencies. We cannot blame the government alone for such sporadic incidents as it has proved itself efficient in quelling some dangerous communal conflicts in Dharan of Eastern Nepal and a religious conflict in a township in Far Western Nepal.

> To solve the grievances of the people, the government and the political parties must try and tackle each problem from the roots.

But to solve the grievances of the people, the government and the political parties must try and tackle each problem from the roots. This is easier said than done, but one success has been seen in the efforts of the Nepal Electricity Authority which has not only been able to cut down load shedding, but also to generate more electricity that Nepal can export to neighbouring countries. The help of donors in contributing towards the building of transmission lines has helped in this effort of the government and NEA.

In this manner, the political parties, which once strongly criticized any Nepali going abroad for work, are now pleading with more developed countries to give job opportunities to Nepali citizens. They should also try and correct the situation here in the country itself so that Nepali youths do not have to go abroad for better job opportunities and better income as well. It is indeed a sad aspect for the nation to see an exodus of young skilled or unskilled manpower leaving the country in hordes, when it needs their presence here. Meanwhile, it is also not good that there seems to be a divided mentality within certain political parties and differences amongst them as well. This does not bode well for the very cause they fought for during difficult times. The parties must set aside such differences for now, when the nation and the whole system, as said by PM Dahal himself, is being challenged.

Good governance

Meanwhile, it can be seen that the government has not been sitting down idly and it has been carrying out many works, as reported even by the media outlets who usually criticize the work of any government which comes to power. But like pointed out by an analyst, people in high posts, whether they are ministers, top level bureaucrats or officials in the security forces, must also be more responsible and they should be held accountable, whether in corruption cases or incidents like the one that happened in Balkumari some days back. Only punishing or suspending the small fries is not enough. For the government to show its commitment for good governance, the so called 'high profile' officials must also be punished for any wrong doings in their part. Accountability is important for any system or government to be more effective in its tasks for development of the nation.

(The author is a former chief editor of this daily)

Creating Domestic Employment

Dr. Lok Nath Bhusal



Annually, about half a million workforce enters our labour market. This is the supply side. On the demand side, not more than 100,000 of them get some type of employment at home, owing to limited economic activities. This excess supply of labour has been creating unemployment problem in the country. The government has been attempting to overcome this problem by allowing its youth and productive population to go abroad for work. With the global control of COVID-19, in the last fiscal year alone, about 771 thousand labour permits were issued by the Department of Foreign Employment. This figure is more than the annual entry of youth in our labour market, indicating the accumulation of unemployed youth due to COVID-19. About 2500 youth are flying for foreign employment daily.

A pressing question then is to understand why we have failed to create enough job opportunities at home? A single sentence answer to this question would be: There are gaps in creating productive employment and decent work at home. The huge exodus of labour migration has caused labour shortage in various sectors while remittance has become a lifeline and means of upward mobility for many Nepali households. There are also human and social costs of foreign employment. Our natural capitals, such as land, remain untapped. Many of our youth are facing easily preventable death abroad. Other are compromising their family balance.

Innovation

These complications have sacrificed our happiness and overall development. "Gold is meaningless if there is no peace of mind" goes a Nepali conventional wisdom. On the equilibrium, for a resource-rich country like ours, creating more and better employment at home appears to be the lasting developmental solution. Reforms in our education, industry, human capital, decent work and consumption patterns will definitely create enough domestic job opportunities.

Education is both a means and an end of development. Nepal's education has not become employment-friendly. Admission in the general stream is not only too much but also of low quality due to excessive focus on theory. Graduates do not acquire specific skills suitable for the labour market. Reforming education have the potential to create domestic employment as well as greater access to job opportunities. Public investment in education is around 10 per cent of annual budget. This is clearly inadequate to bring desired transformations in this sector. Additional investment must be mobilised for the capacity development of teachers, improving physical infrastructures and bringing out structural and institutional changes. All these factors should facilitate much-awaited innovations in all spheres of our education system, process and outcomes. Laws governing the school, high and technical education must not be further delayed as per the constitutional provisions. They must articulate national interests and raise above petty interests.

All levels of education should develop students physically, intellectually, technically, morally and spiritually as a global and Nepali citizen capable to compete and contribute to the motherland as well as the global humanity in their respective sectors. Private education must be regulated and facilitated. Profit and service have to be renegotiated. Dropouts have to be reduced at all levels. Increased tendency to go abroad for studying and settling has to be reversed through the injection of employment-oriented quality education at home. Old and dysfunctional curriculum must be replaced with innovative contents capable of developing students' capacities for tapping market opportunities.

> All levels of education should develop students physically, intellectually, technically, morally and spiritually as a global and Nepali citizen capable to compete and contribute to the motherland as well as the global humanity.

Industrial revival is absolutely vital for creating domestic employment. Over the years, we have become an importing country as suggested by the ballooning trade deficits. More imports lead to less production at home. If we produce less, we will employ less numbers of workers. This is the root of unemployment and push factor for migration for work abroad. If we continue to import everything, we will never have industries and thereby sustainable employment at home. Industry and Commerce Ministry must play a critical role by creating conducive environment for industrial development in the country.

Creating decent work conditions is equally critical for attracting youth to the domestic labour market. Inadequate pay, unsecure working conditions, huge informality, lack of social security for the future and a deep-seated culture of lack of dignity of work have made our labour market deficient of decent work. Reforms in these areas will attract workers in the domestic labour market. There must be tripartite collaborations among the government, employers and workers to bring about these reforms.

Demographic dividend

Human capital formation is the foundation of domestic employment creation. Nepal's population structure shows that working age population constitute about 62 percent of our population. This situation is known as demographic dividend. If this economically active population is not healthy, educated, properly skilled and ethical, country's development potential is clearly undermined. Resources and efforts must be directed for human capital development. Additionally, if this population group is not mobilised within the country, Nepal will never move to the developed country status.

Consumer awareness is crucial for domestic employment creation. Consumption of domestic goods and services creates demand for such goods. This creates incentives for domestic producers to supply. And this is how more workers will be demanded in our factories and industries. Logically, families consuming imported goods must export their family members abroad for work and earning. Every aware consumer must understand this nexus and prioritise domestic products.

In sum, constitution and periodic plans have articulated policies to create more and better domestic employment opportunities. Article 33 of the constitution has the provision for rights to employment. Non-compliance to these policies have forced people to search for overseas employment. Foreign employment has both human and social costs while domestic resources remain untapped. Employment-oriented education, industrialisation, decent work, enhancing the quality of workforce and consumption awareness are immediately needed if Nepal has to create more and better employment opportunities at home. This is also the foundation of national prosperity and happiness.

(Dr. Bhusal works on Poverty, Unemployment and Social Protection.)

50 YEARS AGO

THE RISING NEPAL

January 5, 1974

Nepalese Rice For Bangladesh

Kathmandu, Jan. 4: Five thousand metric tonnes of rice will be exported to Bangladesh from Jhapa by the end of January.

NOTICE TO CONTRIBUTORS

TRN welcomes articles, letters and comments from our valued readers and contributors.

Please email your contributions to:

trnfeatures@hotmail.com
trnfeatures@gmail.com

Or send them to
P.O. Box 23, Kathmandu, Nepal

READER'S MAIL

Harness Tourism Potential

This is in reference to a news report titled "*Nepal achieves tourism target, but yet to reach pre-COVID level*" published on 4th January, 2023 in your prestigious daily.

According to the news report, Nepal has successfully met its target of bringing in 1 million tourists in 2023, but has failed to surpass the number of visitors from pre-COVID level.

The Ministry of Culture, Tourism and Civil Aviation has highlighted that a total of 1,014,871 tourists arrived in Nepal between January and December of 2023.

Tourism sector is considered to be an integral part of Nepal's economy.

Leveraging upon its rich natural resources, the country has established itself as a major tourist destination.

And the country has the potential to achieve more through tourism.

As the tourism sector is directly and indirectly linked with the lives of many Nepali people, the government



should continue putting efforts into improving it.

The three tiers of government, private sector, embassies and others should continue to attract the attention of the tourists from around the globe.

This will help the country's economy and the livelihood of the people in a good way.

Anukriti Pokharel
Chabahil, Kathmandu

TAILPIECE

A doctor at an insane asylum decided to take his inmates to a baseball game. For weeks in advance, he coached his patients to respond to his commands. When the day of the game arrived, everything seemed to be going well.

As the national anthem started, the doctor yelled, "Up nuts!" And the inmates complied by standing up. After the anthem he yelled, "Down Nuts!" And they all sat. After a home run he yelled, "Cheer nuts!" And they all broke into applause and cheers.

Thinking things were going well, he decides to go get a beer and a hot dog, leaving his assistant in charge. When he returned there was a riot in progress. Finding his assistant, he asked what happened.

Blinken begins new Mideast trip



PHOTO: AFP

US Secretary of State Antony Blinken speaks during a press conference in Tel Aviv, Israel in this file photo taken on November 30, 2023.

AFP
France, Jan. 4

US Secretary of State Antony Blinken will leave Thursday on his fourth crisis trip to the Middle East, an official said, as fears mount that the Israel-Hamas conflict will spiral into a regional war.

The top US diplomat will leave Thursday evening from Washington on a trip that will include Israel, the US official said Wednesday on condition of anonymity.

It will mark Blinken's fourth trip to the region and fifth to Israel – excluding a visit accompanying President Joe Biden – since Hamas militants led the deadliest-ever attack inside Israel on October 7, triggering massive Israeli retaliation.

Likewise, Saudi Arabia rejects "extremist remarks" by two Israeli ministers who called for the displacement of Gaza's population, the reoccupation of the strip and the construction of settlements, the foreign ministry said in a statement on Thursday.

Finance Minister Bezalel Smotrich, one of the senior figures in Israeli Prime Minister Binyamin Netanyahu's coalition, had called on Sunday for Palestinian residents of Gaza to leave the besieged enclave, making way for Israelis who could "make the desert bloom."

Israel's far-right National Security Minister Itamar Ben Gvir said on Monday that Israel "must promote a solution to encourage the emigration of Gaza's residents".

Meanwhile, four Hezbollah fighters were killed overnight in southern Lebanon, the Iran-backed movement confirmed Thursday, in what Lebanese state media said were Israeli strikes on the border town of Naqura.

The deaths, which according to a source close to the powerful militant group include a local Hezbollah leader, follow a strike in a Beirut suburb this week that killed a senior Hamas leader, raising regional tensions as war rages in Gaza.

Hezbollah said in a statement the four fighters had been killed "on the road to Jerusalem" – a phrase it has been using to announce deaths of its members due to Israeli fire since the Israel-Hamas war started on October 7.

The group did not elaborate, but a source close to Hezbollah told AFP that the four were killed in Naqura near the Israeli border, adding that one of them was the movement's local leader.

Lebanon's official National News Agency said Israeli aircraft "carried out raids on the centre of Naqura, which destroyed a home and damaged surrounding houses".

Myanmar junta to release 9,000 prisoners



PHOTO: AFP

Members of an honour guard march during a ceremony marking Myanmar's 76th anniversary of Independence Day in Naypyidaw, Myanmar on January 4, 2024.

AFP
Myanmar, Jan. 4

Myanmar's junta announced an amnesty for more than 9,000 prisoners on Thursday, part of an annual release to mark the country's Independence Day. The traditional event comes as the army, which took power in a military coup in 2021, faces growing resistance from allied groups in the country's north.

A coalition of ethnic armed groups has said it has captured military positions and border hubs vital for trade with China, posing a serious threat to the junta, according to analysts.

Independence Day in Myanmar has previously been marked by a parade in the capital Naypyidaw, followed by an address from junta chief Min Aung Hlaing. But the junta leader was absent this year, leaving a subordinate to read prepared remarks in his stead.

In a statement Thursday, the State Administration Council, as the junta calls itself, said it had "granted amnesty to 9,652 prisoners from respective prisons and jails as a gesture for the 76th Independence Day and to respect the peace in peoples' hearts and minds".

There was no immediate indication that political detainees were among those to be released. In a separate statement, the junta said that 114 foreign prisoners were among those granted amnesty and would be deported "on bilateral relations and humanitarian grounds".

In the commercial capital Yangon, friends and family members of prisoners gathered outside Insein prison, where detainees were to be released.

Hopes fade for survivors of Japan quake

AFP
Wajima, Jan. 4

Thousands of Japanese rescuers on Thursday battled rubble and blocked roads as hopes faded for dozens listed as missing three days after a devastating earthquake that killed at least 81.

Hundreds of people in more than a dozen communities remained cut off in Ishikawa prefecture in central Japan, devastated by the 7.5-magnitude quake on New Year's Day.

Regional governor Hiroshi Hase told a disaster management meeting that as of 4:00 pm (0700 GMT), 72 hours after the quake, "the survival rate of those in need of rescue is said to drop precipitously".

"This is the worst catastrophe" in the current Reiwa era in the Japanese calendar, which began in 2019 when the current emperor ascended the throne, Prime Minister Fumio Kishida said.

"Access to this area was extremely difficult, partly due to the geographical constraints of the affected area being a peninsula, and partly due to the intermittent occurrence of major quakes," he said.

"The situation remains difficult, but we will continue to do our utmost to support the victims."

The powerful main tremor, followed by hundreds of aftershocks, injured at least 330 people, local authorities said. Authorities published a list on Thursday of 79 people whose whereabouts were unknown.



PHOTO: AFP

Scenes of destruction were seen in the coastal town of Wajima.

With hundreds sleeping in emergency shelters, further scenes of destruction were seen by AFP in the coastal towns of Anamizu and Wajima, including burnt-out cars in a market area ravaged by fire.

Thousands of soldiers, firefighters and police officers from across Japan, assisted by sniffer dogs, combed through the rubble of collapsed wooden houses and toppled commercial buildings for signs of life.

Yasuhiro Morita, working with a rescue unit in Wajima, said that his dog Elza was trained to bark when it finds a body.

"But today, she just wandered off toward bystanders instead, which likely means there was no body inside," Morita told AFP.

"This is where my grandma's house used to be, but it's all burned down," said Shinichi Hirano, 47.

China and US hold rival military drills

AFP
France, Jan. 4

The drills follow tense standoffs between Beijing and Manila in disputed reefs that saw vessels from the two countries collide and Chinese ships blast water cannon at Philippine boats.

China last month voiced growing frustration and anger at the Philippines' unexpectedly bold tactics, warning its neighbour to exercise "caution".

And footage shared by state broadcaster CCTV and the Chinese military on Thursday showed what they called "live fire drills" taking place over the sea.

One video, shared by the Chinese military's Southern Theatre Command, showed jets taking off and firing missiles that then struck targets.

Neither state media nor the military said when the footage was taken, only that it took place recently.

But its release came a day after China announced a deployment of its navy and air force in the South China Sea on Wednesday and Thursday.

The drills coincided with a two-day exercise by the US and the Philippines in the disputed waters, involving an aircraft carrier strike group led by the USS Carl Vinson.

The US said the drills would "enhance our ability to coordinate on maritime domain awareness and other shared security interests".

Armed Forces of the Philippines Public Affairs Chief Xerxes Trinidad told AFP on Thursday they took place between the Recto Bank and Scarborough Shoal, where clashes took place last month.

Beijing condemned them as "provocative military activities" aimed at "flaunting their military might".

Foreign ministry spokesman Wang Wenbin said the exercises were "detrimental to management and control of the maritime situation and related disputes".

"We urge relevant countries to stop their irresponsible actions and earnestly respect the efforts of countries in the region to maintain peace and stability in the South China Sea," he said.

Beijing, he pledged, would "continue to firmly safeguard its territorial sovereignty and maritime rights and interests".

Beijing claims almost the entire South China Sea and has ignored an international tribunal ruling that its assertions have no legal basis.

It deploys boats to patrol the busy waterway and has built artificial islands that it has militarised to reinforce its claims.

PRISM

Crocodile jumps into boat

Australia: Wildlife officials in Queensland, Australia, are investigating a report of a large crocodile that jumped out of the water and into an angler's boat.

The Queensland Department of Environment, Science and Innovation said a man was fishing in his tin boat at Jane Creek, near St. Helen's Beach in an area north of Mackay, when he spotted a crocodile nearby.

"The man said he had been fishing around four hours and when he saw the large crocodile approaching the boat, he moved to the back of the vessel and started the engine," Senior Wildlife Officer Jane Burns said in a news release. "The crocodile swum under the tinnie, then turned and launched itself up and into the vessel with its jaws wide open."

YouTubers build tallest Popsicle stick

Brazil: A pair of Brazilian YouTubers broke a Guinness World Record by erecting a 78.1-foot tower made from Popsicle sticks.

Iberê Thenório and Mari Fulfaro, hosts of the educational YouTube channel Manual do Mundo, led the efforts to assemble the world's tallest Popsicle stick structure in Sao Paulo.

The hosts said it took a team of 16 people to accomplish the feat.

"The most challenging part was to put the tower up," Thenório told Guinness World Records.

"It was too tall and had a lot of fragile connections. It broke three times before we could put it up. And shortly after it fell due to wind.

(AP)

Bangladeshi youth aspire for stable future as nation goes to vote

AP
Dhaka, Jan. 4

At a technology center in Bangladesh's capital, young women huddle around a computer, discussing a coding issue. Many of them make the daily trip to Dhaka on the shining new metro rail while scouring their smartphones for the latest on social media.

For decades, political battles in Bangladesh have been fought on the streets, often with violence, by parties led by two powerful women. But there are signs of a generational change as the country of 169 million heads into another general election Sunday.

While an opposition boycott and acrimony tarnish the polls, millions of young voters are seeking a different narrative. A burgeoning technology industry, lively e-commerce and a growing public digital infrastructure are helping one of South Asia's fastest growing economies capitalize on a tech-savvy workforce that is demanding change from politicians.

Ahead of the election, boycotted by the main opposition led by former Prime Minister Khaleda Zia, Prime Minister Sheikh Hasina is trying to woo first-time voters with her government's "Digital Bangladesh" project, promising a "smart Bangladesh" by 2041 and 15 million new jobs for young people by 2030.



PHOTO: AP

An aerial view of roads and flyovers in Dhaka, Bangladesh, Aug. 29, 2023.

In an address at a large election rally outside Dhaka on Saturday, Hasina asked young voters for their support "so that the advancement of Bangladesh continues."

Some are listening. Shahrima Tanjin Arni, 26, who teaches law at Dhaka University, called Hasina a bold leader with a vision for a digital future.

"She holds the values of the past, but at the same time, she has a progressive thinking in her progressive heart, which is not very common in Bangladeshi societies," Arni said.

The previous two general elections were marred by allegations of vote-rigging and intimidation, which authorities denied. Hasina, seeking a fourth consecutive term, pledges a free and fair election. But her critics allege she is undermining the process for an inclusive election and suppressing the opposition, which Hasina blames for violence.

Younger voters say they want a break from the highly polarized political culture and concerns over democratic rights.

"My desire is that ... people of Bangladesh will freely exercise their voting right, their freedom of speech will be ensured and the justice system will work independently," said Abdur Rahim Rony, a student at Dhaka University. "I also wish that no political party or the government will interfere with the constitutional institutions."

One-fourth of the country's population is in the 15-29 age group, according to the Bangladesh Bureau of Statistics. Almost one-third of the country's 119.1 million registered voters are between 18 and 30. An October survey by the Bangladesh Citizen's Platform for SDGs, or sustainable development goals, conducted online and involving 5,075 people aged 18-35, found that 69% of young people in Bangladesh considered corruption and nepotism as the main obstacles to development as the country sheds its least-developed economic status and grows into a middle-income developing country.

"We don't want any chaos on streets or violence. When I will finish my study, I wish to do a job or start my own business peacefully," said 20-year-old Raul Tamjid Rahman, a first-time voter and computer science student at Brac University in Dhaka. "It's a call from our generation to our politicians and policymakers."

The telecom boom in Bangladesh began in 1997 when Hasina issued free licenses to three operators to run the mobile phone sector. It was a key chance for global companies to invest in one of the world's most densely populated countries.

"The expansion of digital economy is a miracle that is bringing changes to the economic landscape, with young people at the helm," said Abu Saeed Khan, a senior policy fellow at the Sri Lanka-based think tank LIRNEasia.

TODAY IN HISTORY

1781 – American Revolutionary War: Richmond, Virginia, is burned by British naval forces led by former American general Benedict Arnold.

1900 – Irish nationalist leader John Edward Redmond calls for revolt against British rule.

1944 – The Daily Mail becomes the first major London newspaper to be published on both sides of the Atlantic Ocean.

1991 – Somali Civil War: The United States Embassy to Somalia in Mogadishu is evacuated by helicopter airlift days after the outbreak of violence in Mogadishu.

1993 – The oil tanker MV Braer runs aground on the coast of the Shetland Islands, spilling 84,700 tons of crude oil.

2014 – A launch of the communication satellite GSAT-14 aboard the GSLV MK.II D5 marks the first successful flight of an Indian cryogenic engine.

NC CALLS CENTRAL WORK EXECUTION COMMITTEE MEET

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 4

Nepali Congress has called its Central Work Execution Committee meeting for Saturday.

NC chief secretary Krishna Prasad Paudel in an official statement issued on Thursday said that the meeting would be held at 1.00 pm at the party's central office, Sanepa, Lalitpur.

The meeting likely to finalise the names of candidate of the upcoming election to member of the National Assembly.

CIAA HOLDS PROVINCIAL LEVEL INTERACTION IN DHANGADHI

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 4

The Commission for the Investigation of Abuse of Authority (CIAA) informed that a provincial-level interaction programme on corruption control and promotion of good governance was held in Dhangadhi of Sudurpashchim Province on Thursday.

Speaking at the programme, the Chief Secretary of Sudurpashchim Province Dr. Hari Lamsal stressed that civil servants should perform their duties in accordance with the law.

Minister for Physical Infrastructure Development of Sudurpashchim Province, Prakash Bahadur Deuba said that it was everyone's responsibility to control corruption.

Stating that the CIAA played a significant role in promoting good governance, he informed that the provincial government had adopted a zero-tolerance policy against corruption to enhance good governance.

Similarly, Minister for Economic Affairs and Planning Naresh Kumar Shahi said that good governance could be achieved through the cooperation of a responsible and innovative civil society, selfless and dedicated politicians and a positive and proactive bureaucratic system.

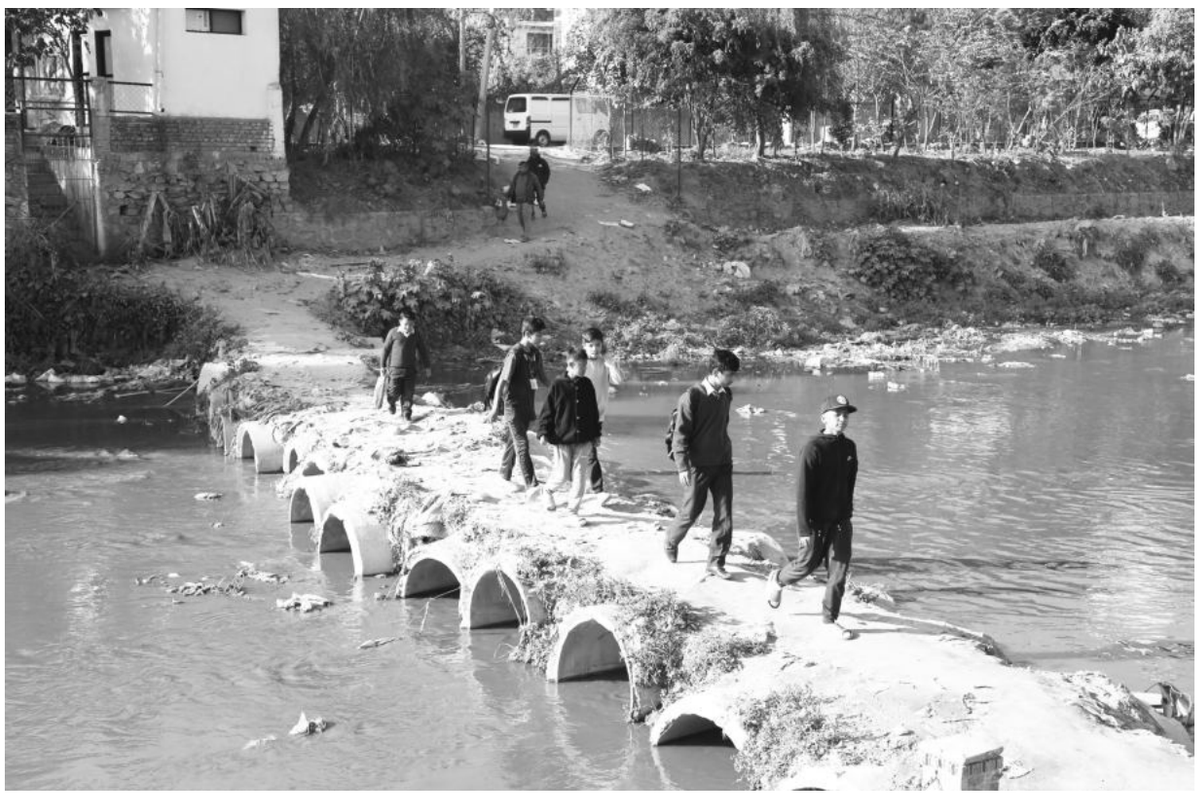


PHOTO: KABIN ADHIKARI/TRN

School children crossing Bishnumati River through a makeshift bridge near Kankeshwari Temple in Kathmandu on Thursday.

Wild elephants threaten locals of Sarlahi, Morang

BY OUR CORRESPONDENTS
Sarlahi/Morang, Jan. 4

Wild elephants caused damage to two houses in Paitalis Bigha at Murtia of Barathawa Municipality-9, Sarlahi, on Wednesday night.

Two elephants emerged suddenly from the Murtiya forest and destroyed the houses of Apsara Thakuri and Badri Gurung. The lower floor of Thakuri's two-storey house suffered damage, and elephants destroyed 12 quintals of paddy and 2 quintals of rice stored in her house.

Locals said that two windowpanes on the top floor of Gurung's house were also broken.

Tulsi Prasad Luitel, Ward Chairman of Barhathwa Municipality-9, said that the elephants that entered the village at midnight on Wednesday were chased away by the villagers.

Elephants caused havoc and ended up destroying the recently planted corn crops, amriso (broom) grass and banana plants of the locals. The farmers reported that the wild elephants, which had previously entered the Murtiya area during the festival, had destroyed their paddy.

Three days ago, two wild elephants entered the Srinagar area of Ishwarpur Municipality-13 and caused damage to potatoes and other crops.

Meanwhile, in Urlabari, wild elephants entered the settlement from the forest area of Urlabari Municipality, causing panic among the residents.

The elephants are moving towards Urlabari through Jharna Tole, located in Ratuwamai Municipality-9, starting from the ring road of Goppeshwar Mandir in Ward No. 10, passing via Rastra Nirman Boarding School.

A large number of security personnel have been deployed in the area after nine wild elephants entered the settlement.

Locals reported that on Thursday morning, the elephant moved towards Urlabari through Ward Nos. 9 and 10 of Ratuwamai. The elephants, which initially went to Bakraha River from Urlabari-9, have re-entered Urlabari-8, the police informed.

Nar Bahadur Moktan, Ward Chairman of Urlabari-9, said that the elephants are currently heading towards the Bakraha River.

The Senior Sub Inspector Manoj Yadav of the Area Police Office, Urlabari-9 said that elephants that entered the village are currently residing in the forest of the Peace Zone area of Urlabari-9.

'Free universities from political interference'

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 4

Nepali Congress leader Dr. Shekhar Koirala has underlined the need for running the universities under the board of trustees.

Speaking at a function organised by the Sunkoshi-Indrawati Society, Sindhupalchwok in the Capital on Thursday, Dr. Koirala said that universities could be saved only when they were made free of political interference.

Dr. Koirala said Prime Minister Pushpa Kamal Dahal Prachanda's recent remark about making the universities free from politics was praiseworthy.

"However, within a few days he gave another gift stating that the Prime Minister will be the chancellor of the Tribhuvan University," he said.

Dr. Koirala said Nepali universities could collapse if corrective measures were not taken at the earliest.

He accused the government of focusing only on increasing universities without paying attention to the quality of education, and it was a bad sign.

Dr. Koirala said that even Tribhuvan University itself was running in a bad situation and its international status was decreasing due to declining quality of education.

He said that of the total students who passed grade 12 examinations last year, 127,000 students flew abroad.

"Most of them went overseas seeking quality education as we are not giving quality and contextual education in the country," he said.

Dr. Koirala also said that the medical sector of the country was likely to collapse in the near future due to mistakes committed by the government in medical education.

He said 135 nursing colleges were opened in the border area as the government and big nursing colleges were not running PCL courses in the country. He said without producing sufficient nurses, doctors alone cannot run the health sector.

Dr. Koirala also questioned the government on whether or not it would be viable to run medical college in every district as advocated and if the country could withstand that.

Airstrike in central Baghdad kills Iran-backed militia leader

AP
Badhdad, Jan. 4

A U.S. airstrike on the headquarters of an Iran-backed militia in central Baghdad on Thursday killed a high-ranking militia commander, militia officials said.

Thursday's strike comes amid mounting regional tensions fueled by the Israel-Hamas war and fears that it could spill over into surrounding countries. It also coincides with a push by Iraqi officials for US-led coalition forces to leave the country.

The Popular Mobilization Force, or PMF, a coalition of militias that is nominally under the control of the Iraqi military, announced in a statement that its deputy head of operations in Baghdad, Mushtaq Taleb al-Saidi, or "Abu Taqwa," had been killed "as a result of brutal American aggression."

A U.S. official who spoke on condition of anonymity to provide information that has not yet been publicly released confirmed that U.S. forces conducted a strike on a vehicle in Baghdad on Monday against the group Harakat al-Nujaba. The group, one of the militias within PMF, was designated a terrorist organization by Washington in 2019.

Iraqi military spokesman Yehia Rasool said in a statement that the Iraqi army blames the U.S.-led International Coalition Forces for the "unprovoked attack on an Iraqi security body operating in accordance with the powers granted to it by" the Iraqi military.

The primary mission of the U.S.-led coalition is to fight the Islamic State, the Sunni extremist militant group that continues to carry out periodic attacks in Iraq despite having lost its hold on the territory it once controlled in 2017. Since then, the coalition has transitioned from a combat role to an advisory and training mission.

Nepal set to make millions through carbon...

Nepal has not earned money from carbon trade from its forest yet, but in 2009, the World Bank had provided $10 million for capacity development.

During COP26 in Glasgow, Nepal government signed a letter of intent with the LEAF Coalition for another carbon trade initiative. According to the agreement, the government will sell 30 million tonnes of CO2e for $10 per tonne between 2022 to 2026, focusing on Bagmati, Gandaki, and Lumbini Provinces," Khanal said. Work is under way as per the agreement, he informed.

REDD+ in Nepal

Nepal has been actively involved in the implementation of REDD+ (Reducing Emissions from Deforestation and Forest Degradation) initiatives. REDD+ is a global effort aimed at mitigating climate change by reducing greenhouse gas emissions from deforestation and forest degradation, promoting sustainable forest management, and enhancing forest carbon stocks.

The programme is also to increase livelihood assets, food security and diversify employment opportunities of forest-dependent people, particularly the poor and marginalised.

REDD+ is a plan made by the United Nations to help countries take care of their forests. The goal is to stop cutting down too many trees, keep the forests healthy, and manage the land in a way that's good for the environment.

To reach the goal set by the United Nations, Nepal has implemented various tasks. The government made the existing community-based forests better, provided national forests for communities to take care of, and supported private forests. The programme has also been implemented in about 30,000 hectares of private forests in 13 districts.

The ER Programme in the Tarai has a goal to reduce deforestation and forest degradation over 2.4 million hectares of land, which holds 20 per cent of Nepal's forest cover.

The majority of the first instalment funds will be directed to the local level to manage forests, including community forests, partnership forests, and national forests. The draft for fund distribution has been formulated and forwarded to the Ministry of Finance for approval. Khanal stated that funds from the World Bank will be received during this period.

"For the second instalment, the government plans to submit the report in 2025 and expects to receive the funds by the end of that year," he added.

Nepal currently has 44.74 per cent of its land covered by forests and wooded areas. The Second Nationally Determined Contributions (NDC) outline the government's goal to maintain 45 per cent forest cover (including less than 4 per cent wooded land) across the country by 2030.

The plan also targets sustainable management of 50 per cent of Tarai and Inner Tarai forests, along with 25 per cent of middle hills and mountain forests, by 2030, with support from REDD+ initiatives.

Nepal's annual per capita carbon emission is among the lowest globally, standing at 0.29 tonnes.

Nepal sends ritual *Bhar* to India

BY LAXMI CHAUDHARY
Janakpurdham, Jan. 4



Nepal's Janaki Temple has dispatched special Bhar (food and non-food items gifted to married daughters and their in-laws) offerings to India's Ayodhya for the inauguration of the new Ram Temple there.

A team of 251 people, led by Ram Roshan Das, successor to the Mahanth (head priest) of the Janaki Temple, and Manoj Kumar Sah, mayor of Janakpurdham Sub-Metropolitan City, left Janakpur on Thursday with 1,500 baskets of Bhar.

They were seen off by Chief Minister of Madhes Province Saroj Kumar Yadav and Nepali Congress leader and member of the House of Representatives Bimalendra Nidhi. They shall be attending the inauguration of Lord Ram's new temple in Ayodhya on January 22 in the capacity of the god's in-laws.

In Mithila, it is customary for a family to send jewellery, clothes, lotus seeds, fruits, sweets and more, to their married daughter, her husband and her husband's family when she and her in-laws move into a new house. Thursday's Bhar is also in line with this tradition, informed Das.

Das had earlier appealed to the people of Janakpur to help arrange items for the Bhar offering. They listened to his request and the Janaki Temple team was able to manage everything needed to be sent to India by Wednesday, Das said. Devotees from all over the city presented their donations in bamboo baskets and wrote their names on the outside.

On Thursday, the Bhar team left Janakpurdham and reached Birgunj via Malangwa, Simraungadh and Gadhimai. If everything goes as planned, the team will reach Ayodhya on Friday and will present their ritual items to the Ram Temple Trust at the pre-determined time of 9 am on Saturday.

Nepal, India sign energy trade....

Space India Limited (NSIL) signed an agreement for the launch services for Munal Satellite on Polar Satellite Launch Vehicle (PSLV).

According to the Kathmandu University High School (KUHS), Munal is a part of the High School Consortium Satellite Project, done in collaboration between Nepal Academy of Science and Technology (NAST), Nepal, and the International Institute of Space Technology for Economic Development (INSTED), Thailand. High School Consortium Satellite Project's goal is to develop the world's first high school CubeSat constellation.

The CubeSat name Munal from Nepal is being developed at Space Systems Laboratory (SSL) located at KUHS. Similarly, handover of fifth tranche of the post Jajarkot-earthquake relief supply provided by the Government of India was also handed over to Nepal during the meeting. In addition, India will provide financial assistance package for the post Jajarkot-earthquake reconstruction.

Meanwhile, the Ministry of External Affairs (MEA) of India said in a post in X that various aspects of Nepal-India relations were discussed on the occasion under the thematic areas ranging from economic relations to people to people relations.

Dr. Jaishankar termed the JC meeting 'a comprehensive and productive'.

Discussions of the meeting were focused on our overall bilateral ties, trade and economic relations, land, rail and air connectivity projects, cooperation in defense and security, agriculture, energy, power, water resources, disaster management, tourism, civil aviation, people-to-people and cultural exchanges and development partnership.

However, issues like the new air-route, border management and trade deficit reduction couldn't see any progress. The India-Nepal Joint Commission was established in 1987 and provides a platform for both ministers to review all aspects of the bilateral partnership.

Indian Minister calls on....

India in June 2023 which imparted a new momentum to the ties between the two countries. He has also taken the JC meeting as a follow-up to that visit.

"Friendship is indeed unique (between Nepal and India), and our partnership is moving from strength to strength," said Dr. Jaishankar. He also called on former prime minister and President of the Nepali Congress, Sher Bahadur Deuba and former PM and Chairman of CPN-UML, KP Sharma Oli.

Likewise, he also met with Loktantrik Samajwadi Party chair Mahantha Thakur, Janata Samajwadi Party-Nepal chair Upendra Yadav and Janamat Party chair CK Raut

Dr. Jaishankar arrived Kathmandu on Thursday morning leading Indian delegation to the JC meeting and will leave for New Delhi on Friday afternoon.

GOVERNMENT OF NEPAL (GoN)
MASTER GENERAL OF ORDNANCE (PROVISION)
NEPALI ARMY HEADQUARTERS, BHADRAKALI, KATHMANDU, NEPAL

Invitation e-Bids for Tool Production Items & Tools for CN/CNC Machine and Other Workshop Machines

First Date of Publication: 05 January, 2024

1. The Master General of Ordnance (MGO) (Provision), Nepali Army Headquarters invites electronic bids from eligible bidders for the procurement of the following items required for the Nepali Army under International Competitive Bidding (ICB) procedures specified in Public Procurement Act and Regulations:

S. N.	Contract Identification No:	Description of Item	Quantity	Price of Bid Document NRs	Bid Bond Amount NRs	Bid Validity	Pre-bid Meeting	Last date of Bid submission	Bid Opening	Remarks
1.	MGO/Tool Production Items & Tools for CNC/NC Machine and Other Workshop Machines/080/81/30 (DDP)	Tool Production Items & Tools for CNC/NC Machine and Other Workshop Machines	Various	3,000.00	2,27,000.00	90 Days	1100 hours NST of 21 January 2024	1200 hours NST of 20 February 2024	1300 hours NST of 20 February 2024	CIP-Sundarijal Arsenal Karyalaya, Sundarijal, Kathmandu, Nepal

2. Eligible Bidders may visit PPMO's e-GP system www.bolpatra.gov.np/egp or obtain further information and inspect the bidding documents at the Office of MGO (Provision), Nepali Army Headquarters, Bhadrakali, Kathmandu, Nepal (Tel. +977-1-5979124) during office hours. Bids must be accompanied by bid security, amounting to above mentioned **bid bond amount** (Equivalent amount in bid currency at selling exchange rate published by Nepal Rastra Bank on bid notice publication date).
3. Fee of bidding document must be deposited in Account Name Master General of Ordnance (Provision.), Name of the Bank: Nepal Bank Ltd., Bhugol Park Kathmandu, Office Code No: **345013563,** Revenue Account No: **00101000000001001001** & Revenue Title (Rajaswa Shirshak) No: 14229.

Women in Barahakshetra play Panche Baja



BY BABURAM KARKI
Barahakshetra, Jan. 4

The women of Singha Bahini Panche Baja Protection Group have become exemplary, proving that given the opportunity, they can be as capable as men in playing traditional instruments.

In recent times, Panche Baja has been disappearing from villages, prompting women in Barahakshetra Municipality-7 Devighat to form a group to preserve the traditional Nepali musical instruments.

Women started playing the Nepali traditional musical instruments to protect the Baja and make the women skilled, and later they formed a group.

After they stopped finding people to play the Panche Baja in the auspicious functions such as weddings and other pujas in the village, women learned to play the Baja and took up protection.

Shushila Udas, President of Singha Bahini Panche Baja Protection Group, said that the women learned to play Panche Baja for thirty days last year with the financial support of Barahakshetra Municipality.

President Udas said that they go to play at weddings and other events, charging between Rs. 15,000 to Rs. 35,000 per day depending on the distance.

Since August, the women have earned Rs. 250,000, receiving bookings for weddings, sacred thread ceremonies, Diwali, and pujas.

Women who have learned to play the Panche Baja have started receiving bookings for weddings, sacred thread ceremonies, Diwali and pujas in advance.

President Udas said that they have already been booked for weddings from January to March.

Women who purchased five instruments on a loan of Rs. 180,000 and, through their earnings, have successfully repaid the loan, she added.

Hiranya Karki, a local, acknowledged the progress made by the women's group in protecting the Panche Baja in Barahakshetra Municipality.

A 66-year-old Radha Niraula, who started playing the Sanahi, said that playing the instrument, which she had never played in her life, was a little off-putting at first, but now she is getting comfortable.

She said, "We need everyone's cooperation in this campaign, which was started saying that Panche Baja should be preserved.

Maghe Sankranti festival to be held from January 14

BY OUR CORRESPONDENT
Beni, Jan. 4



The Maghe Sankranti festival is set to take place in Beni, the headquarters of Myagdi district.

The event aims to bring back the traditional Maghe Sankranti fair, highlighting local products and encouraging domestic tourism with a special focus on the participation of women entrepreneurs. At a press conference held on Thursday, the organisers announced the three-day fair would be held from January 14-16.

Ambika Shrestha, the chairperson of the Women's Enterprise Development Committee under the Myagdi Chamber of Commerce and Industry, emphasised the prime focus on exhibiting local products and preserving cultural heritage during the fair.

The primary objective is to enhance tourism through the continuation of the traditional Maghe Sankranti fair in Beni, said Shrestha.

The Women's Enterprise Development Committee informed that the festival will highlight the exhibition of agricultural produce from all local levels of the district, tableau displays representing various castes, diverse sports competitions, mother dance contests and performances by local and national artists.

Bel Bahadur Katuwal, President of the Myagdi Chamber of Commerce and Industry, expressed optimism during the press conference, anticipating that the fair organised by women would contribute significantly to the district's tourism promotion.

Britney Spears denies working on new album

PTI
New York, Jan. 4



Shutting down rumours that she is working on a new album, pop singer Britney Spears said she will "never return to the music industry".

The singer shared a post on Instagram alluding to reports that surfaced on Wednesday about Spears potentially tapping Charli XCX and writer Julia Michaels for an unannounced record, her first in nearly a decade.

"Just so we're clear most of the news is trash. They keep saying I'm turning to random people to do a new album … I will never return to the music industry ."

"When I write, I write for fun or I write for other people !!! For those of you who have read my book, there's loads you don't know about me …" the singer wrote.

Spears claimed she has anonymously "written over 20 songs for other people" during the past two years.

"I'm a ghostwriter and I honestly enjoy it that way !!!" she said.

The 42-year-old also cleared the air around her memoir "The Woman In Me", saying it was released with her approval.

"People are also saying my book was released without my approval illegally and that's far from the truth… have you read the news these days??? I'm so loved and blessed!!!" she added.

Spears' most recent recordings include two singles: "Hold Me Closer", a 2022 duet with Elton John, and "Mind Your Business", a collaboration with will.I.Am, the latter originally recorded for her 2013 album, 'Britney Jean'.

TRIAL POSTPONED FOR MAN CHARGED IN 2022 STABBING OF AUTHOR SALMAN RUSHDIE

AP
Mayville, N.Y, Jan. 4

The New Jersey man charged with stabbing "The Satanic Verses" author Salman Rushdie is allowed to seek material related to Rushdie's upcoming memoir about the attack before standing trial, a judge ruled Wednesday. Jury selection in Hadi Matar's attempted murder and assault trial was originally scheduled to start Jan. 8.

Instead, the trial is on hold, since Matar's lawyer argued Tuesday that the defendant is entitled by law to see the manuscript, due out in April 2024, and related material before standing trial. Written or recorded statements about the attack made by any witness are considered potential evidence, attorneys said.

"It will not change the ultimate outcome," Chautauqua County District Attorney Jason Schmidt said of the postponement. A new date has not yet been set. Matar, 26, who lived in Fairview, New Jersey, has been held without bail since prosecutors said he stabbed Rushdie more than a dozen times after rushing the stage at the Chautauqua Institution where the author was about to speak in August 2022.

Deepika Padukone opens up about having children with Ranveer Singh

AGENCIES
Mumbai, Jan. 4



Deepika Padukone has always said that she and her husband, actor Ranveer Singh, love children. The couple started dating in 2012 and got secretly engaged in 2015. They have been married for over five years now, and in a recent interview, Deepika once again shared that she is looking forward to having a child with Ranveer one day.

Deepika opened up about having children in a new interview, and spoke about the values she wants her children to imbibe from her.

"Ranveer and I love children. We look forward to the day when we will start our own family," shared Deepika in a chat with Vogue Singapore. Speaking about her family, she added, "When I meet the people I have grown up with—my aunts, uncles, family friends—they always mention how I haven't changed one bit. That says a lot about our upbringing."

"In this industry, it's easy to get carried away by fame and money. But no one treats me like a celebrity at home. I am a daughter and a sister first. I don't want that to change. My family keeps me grounded and Ranveer and I hope to inculcate the same values in our children," she added.

It was back in 2019 when Deepika Padukone made it clear that while she and Ranveer want children, they weren't thinking about itactively. She had also expressed her annoyance with the societal expectations from couples.

On the work front, Deepika awaited the release of her Siddharth Anand film, Fighter. Deepika will be sharing the screen with Hrithik Roshan. The film is set to release on January 25. Deepika was a part of two big blockbusters of 2023, Pathaan and Jawan.

HOROSCOPE

tarot.com

ARIES: You're ready to cut through the haze, Aries! You may be trying to eliminate any distractions in your life today, particularly if there's a specific issue that's been slowing you down as of late.

CANCER: Honesty can be risky at this time. You might be tired of hiding your feelings regarding a certain subject or person, which may tempt you to say something inappropriate for the setting.

LIBRA: You may presently be searching for an equal. This applies to all connections where someone can act as the yin to your yang -- friendships, relationships, business partnerships, even familial bonds.

CAPRICORN: Friends can embolden you to share more. You might not have realized you were holding back, or perhaps you're naturally guarded, but others likely want to know you.

TAURUS: Various relationships might need some revitalization at this time -- especially if you've been devoting too much time to one person in your life. Others are possibly feeling neglected.

LEO: Relatives may be causing you stress. You could initially receive a burst of motivation to get things done today, but that surge of productive energy might not be able to withstand the demands of those close to you.

SCORPIO: Sincerity could cause problems today, even if it typically works for you. You likely value honesty more than most, as you crave to strip away falsehoods and reach the heart of the matter.

AQUARIUS: You may put your foot in your mouth at any moment. Ambition is relentlessly driving you forward, and because of this boost propelling you forward, you could be lured into saying whatever is on your mind.

GEMINI: Past bad habits can break into your present. Compulsions may tug at you as soon as you set up your routine, and it's probably hard to resist when it feels like it's been so long since you indulged.

VIRGO: Communication can make the difference in the moment. You might be worried about mistakes, or maybe something is rubbing you the wrong way, but for whatever reason, it's difficult to communicate your issue to others.

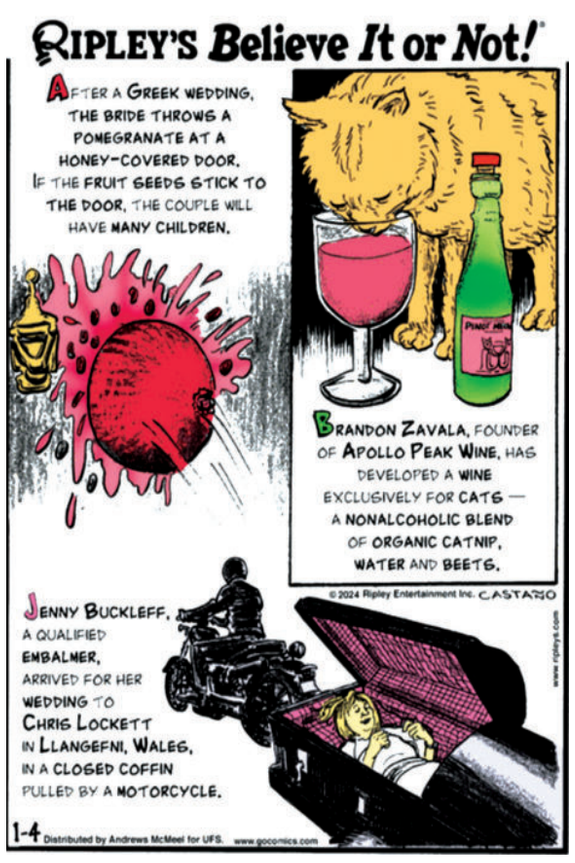
SAGITTARIUS: You might be tempted to give up on something. There may be a project that you're working on that is starting to wear on you, or perhaps even a person in your life that you're tired of spending time with.

PISCES: No one can lower your spirits! You may receive some "constructive" criticism that incites the worry that you aren't doing enough or that you're not taking enough risks.

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NSC SEEKS MINISTERS' QUARTERS IN PULCHOWK FOR ATHLETES

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 4

The National Sports Council (NSC) has decided to request the government for altering the ministers' quarters in Pulchowk, Lalitpur, into accommodation for athletes.

The meeting of the executive committee of the council chaired by member secretary Tanka Lal Ghising concluded that the structures in Pulchowk would remain empty after relocating the ministers' quarters to Bhaisepati.

"Nepal government has been spending millions for the accommodation of national and international athletes during different tournaments. If the buildings in Pulchowk are used for athletes during matches and closed camps, it will be convenient," said Ghising.

Ghising informed that Rs. 123.8 million was spent in seven months while training athletes for the 19th Asian Games. "In the seven-month training period for 13th South Asian Games, Rs. 430 million was spent," he added.

According to the Council, allocating the ministers' quarters for the athletes would be instrumental in the development of the sports sector.

"We have been struggling to keep players under the same roof during closed training camps before important matches and tournaments. If we can provide a genial environment for the players and coaching staffs, it would help the athletes achieve better results," Ghising added.

Minister for Youth and Sports Dig Bahadur Limbu has assured the Council of complete support in endorsing the decision from the government.

"Once our proposal is accepted by the Cabinet, it will show that the government has prioritised the sports sector and the national players would be motivated," Ghising stressed.

Nepal's cricket set for an eventful 2024 at international and domestic stages

BY NAYAK PAUDEL
Kathmandu, Jan. 4



PHOTO: BIKASH/TRN

The Cricket Association of Nepal (CAN) made public a planned calendar for the national and domestic cricket teams amid a press conference at the TU International Cricket Ground on Thursday.

Making public the 2024 Cricket Calendar, Paras Khadka, secretary at CAN, informed that the association has prepared the calendar by analysing the matches in the Cricket World Cup cycle and other leagues.

"Some matches in the calendar have been confirmed while some are under process. We have tried allocating matches for all teams under the CAN," said Khadka, who is also a former captain for national cricket team.

Nepal's cricket team manager Binod Das, a former national captain, informed that the association has also planned several domestic tournaments to provide a platform for new talents.

"We are also creating an A-level team for the men's national. The A team will comprise talented U19 players and those who have not been able to find a proper spot in the men's national team. We will make public our men's A team soon," said Das.

As per the calendar, February and March are the busiest months. The calendar also shows many tournaments for the men's team but sees few fixtures for the women's team.

International Calendar

The international calendar for Nepali cricket will kick off with the ICC U19 Men's World Cup being held in South Africa from 19th January to 11th February. The U19 team will participate in a high-performance training camp in South Africa from January 5 to 12 before the World Cup.

The U19 team will then play in the Men's U19 Asia Cup in October; the tournament-related details have not been made public yet.

Regarding the men's national team, three tri-nation series have been fixed for 2024. Nepal will play against Namibia and the Netherlands in February/March, Canada and Oman in September and the USA and Scotland in October. The matches against Canada and Oman and the USA and Scotland will be under CWC League 2.

"We have received a proposal from Hong Kong to participate in a quadrangular T20 tournament from March 6 to 12. We have not been informed of other opponents," said Khadka.

Nepal will also be participating in the ACC Men's Premier Cup slated for April. However, the venue/host for the tourney has not been decided yet.

After the Premier Cup, Nepal's men's senior team will fly to the USA/West Indies in the month of May for a high-performance training camp before playing in the 2024 T20 World Cup in June. The World Cup will be the major tournament for Nepal's cricket fraternity in 2024.

As the monsoon is at its peak in the months of July and August, CAN has focused on organising different courses for coaches, umpires, scorers, curators and players during June, July and August.

The men's team has also been proposed to visit the United Kingdom in July/August to play against county clubs while it rains in Nepal.

With CAN preparing to create an A team soon, a series has been proposed between Nepal's A team and Canada in February/March. The A team will also face Ireland A in five ODIs and three T20s from March 19 to April 30. The team will also be participating in the Men's T20 Emerging Teams Asia Cup in Sri Lanka in December.

"A T20 tournament has also been proposed from March 20 to April 5 between the main men's team and the A teams of Bangladesh, Sri Lanka and Afghanistan," Khadka informed.

The women's team will start the 2024 campaign by flying to Malaysia on February 8 for the ACC Women's Premier Cup. The calendar shows that several bilateral series have been proposed for the women's team in the upcoming months. The month of September will see Nepal's women's team in the ACC Women's Asia Cup. The tournament is being held in Nepal between six teams.

The only other fixed fixture for the women's team is the participation in the ICC Women's U19 WC qualifier in the UAE in November.

Domestic Calendar

According to Khadka, the U19 team is a foundation for the main team. "We plan to identify aspiring talents at the U16 level, train them properly until the U19 level and prepare them for the main team. We have allocated several domestic tournaments to identify new talents."

The domestic calendar is packed before the month of June with only the Arjun Trophy National T20 Cricket Tournament fixed for November/December. "We are mulling to organise Nepal's T20 premier league in November/December," Khadka informed.

Manmohan Memorial U16 National Cricket Tournament is being organised in Pokhara in a 25-over format from February 11 to 18. A national-level school championship will also be organised between the winners of a similar tournament in all the provinces. A Men's U16 National championship in Pokhara has also been scheduled in March.

The PM Cup Men's National Cricket Tournament from January 12 to February 3 will be one of the major domestic tournaments as the top four teams will further play in the Men's Elite Trophy in February/March/April.

Maiyadevi Cup, a T20 tournament for U19 girls, will also be held in Chitwan from January 24 to February 8.

The CAN has also proposed the Sushil Koirala Championship Trophy and Indo-Nepal T20 Cricket Tournament in Dang/Lamahi and Chitwan for February respectively.

Lalitpur Mayor's Cup (Kathmandu), National T20 Championship (Biratnagar), Bir Ganeshman Singh National Club Championship (Kathmandu), 10th National Games (Surkhet), National Club Championship, Mahendra Nidhi National Cricket Tournament (Janakpur), MM Cup (Sunsari), Saptari Premier League and Koshi Premier League (Bhokraha Narsingh Ground) have been scheduled from March to June.

"Most of the domestic tournaments will be organised outside Kathmandu. Provincial governments have shown keen interest in organising the games. This step will be of great assistance to the cricket sector," said Khadka.

The CAN also looks forward to organising a talent hunt for U16 girls in the month of May.

India beat SA in shortest ever test, draws series

AP/AFP
Capetown, Jan. 4



PHOTO: AP

Indian bowler Jasprit Bumrah celebrates the wicket of Keshav Maharaj during the second day of the second test match against South Africa in Cape Town, Thursday.

India beat South Africa by seven wickets in the shortest test match in cricket history on Thursday.

India crossed the finish line 12 overs after lunch on day two. Chasing 79, it scored 80-3.

Only 642 legitimate deliveries were bowled across four-plus sessions. The previous shortest test — 656 balls— was in 1932 at Melbourne between Australia and South Africa.

Jasprit Bumrah's 6-61 helped to negate Aiden Markram's brilliant 106 to bowl out South Africa out for 176 runs in its second innings by lunch. That gave India a chase of 79, though tricky on a pitch of variable bounce.

Opener Yashaswi Jaiswal scored a quickfire 28 off 23 balls, with six boundaries. He was caught at long leg off Nandre Burger. Rohit Sharma survived two dropped catches, and was unbeaten in the end with 17 not out.

Kagiso Rabada bowled Shubman Gill for 10, and finished the short series with 11 wickets.

Marco Jansen nicked off Virat Kohli for 12 runs when India was four runs from victory. India became the first team from Asia to win in Cape Town and at Newlands. Overall, it was India's fifth win on South African soil.

Warner out for 34

Pakistan captured the key wickets of Australia openers David Warner and Usman Khawaja before rain washed out the second day's play in the third Test in Sydney on Thursday.

Marnus Labuschagne was on 23 and Steve Smith six in their team's 116 for two before play was ended by bad light and rain before tea.

The hosts trailed by 197 runs on a day where Warner was denied a crack at a cherished century in his 112th and final Test match.

Warner was dismissed for 34 and looked annoyed as he left the Sydney Cricket Ground to a standing ovation from his home crowd.

The 37-year-old opener, known in cricket as 'the Bull', was beaten by the extra bounce and turn out of the rough by offspinner Agha Salman to edge off to a delighted Babar Azam at slip.

"I always love batting with Davey (Warner), and it's nice to see him leave on a high," said his long-time friend and opening partner Khawaja.

"He just got a ripper of a ball.

"It's really good to watch that people are getting around him because I believe he deserves it. It's nice to see people give him the accolades he deserves and going out on a high."

Warner, who still has a potential second innings to bat in his last Test, has now scored 8,729 Test runs since his 2011 debut at an average of 44.53 with 26 centuries.

PSG LIFT FRENCH CHAMPIONS TROPHY



AFP
Paris, Jan. 4

Lee Kang-in and Kylian Mbappe scored first-half goals as Paris Saint-Germain won the first silverware of the French season on Wednesday, beating Toulouse 2-0 to claim the Champions Trophy.

Lee, playing his final game before heading off to the Asian Cup in Qatar with South Korea, put PSG ahead in the third minute, leaving Toulouse with an uphill battle at the Parc des Princes. Mbappe then added a superb second goal just before half-time, as Paris claimed the Champions Trophy for the 10th time in the last 11 seasons.

"We were exceptional in the first half. It was our best 45 minutes of my time here," said PSG coach Luis Enrique after claiming his first silverware as a coach since leaving Barcelona in 2017. France's version of a Super Cup is habitually the curtain-raiser to the season and has usually been staged abroad over the last 15 years, including in Tel Aviv at the beginning of the last campaign.

This season's edition was initially due to be played in Thailand in August before being postponed and held in PSG's own stadium rather than on neutral ground.

Home advantage gave Luis Enrique's team, the reigning Ligue 1 champions, the edge as they opened the scoring from one of their first attacks, Lee firing in from Ousmane Dembele's cushioned first-time ball into the middle.

PSG scored just before the interval as Mbappe collected a Bradley Barcola pass before burying a superb shot into the net for his 22nd goal in all competitions this season.

WEATHER

Friday

Sunrise at 6:56 am, Sunset at 5:23 pm

Forecast for Nepal (Friday)

Partly cloudy in the hilly areas of Koshi Province, Bagmati Province, Gandaki Province and Karnali Province and mainly fair in rest of the country. Possibility of light snowfall at one or two places of the high hilly and mountainous region of Koshi Province and Gandaki Province.

Expected Temp.: 16 - 18°C
Rain Probability: ...%

Thursday's Weather Record

Stations	Max. temp. (C)	Min. temp. (C)	Rain (mm)
Dadeldhura	15.8	2.7	0.0
Dipayal	23.5	2.9	0.0
Dhangadi	21.3	7.4	0.0
Birendranagar	21.5	4.0	0.0
Nepalgunj	21.4	8.2	0.0
Jumla	14.8	-6.6	0.0
Ghorahi	21.7	7.2	0.0
Pokhara	20.4	8.1	0.0
Bhairahawa	22.9	9.0	0.0
Simara	24.5	7.5	0.0
Kathmandu	17.2	4.5	0.0
Okhaldhunga	17.8	7.0	0.0
Taplejung	16.0	4.5	0.0
Dhankuta	22.0	8.0	0.0
Biratnagar	25.7	9.8	0.0
Jomsom	10.0	-5.0	0.0*
Dharan	25.5	12.0	0.0*
Lumle	15.5	5.0	0.0*
Janakpur	27.2	7.5	0.0*
Jiri	14.2	-0.7	0.0*

NEPAL RASTRA BANK

FOREIGN EXCHANGE DEPARTMENT

EXCHANGE RATES

January 5, 2024

CURRENCY	UNIT	BUYING	SELLING
Indian Rupee	100	Rs. 160.00	Rs. 160.15

Open Market Exchange Rates
For the purpose of Nepal Rastra Bank

CURRENCY	UNIT	BUYING	SELLING
U.S. Dollar	1	Rs. 132.88	Rs. 133.48
Euro	1	Rs. 145.57	Rs. 146.23
Pound Sterling	1	Rs. 168.82	Rs. 169.59
Swiss Franc	1	Rs. 156.30	Rs. 157.01
Australian Dollar	1	Rs. 89.51	Rs. 89.92
Canadian Dollar	1	Rs. 99.73	Rs. 100.18
Singapore Dollar	1	Rs. 100.08	Rs. 100.53
Japanese Yen	10	Rs. 9.21	Rs. 9.25
Chinese Yuan	1	Rs. 18.58	Rs. 18.67
Saudi Arab Riyal	1	Rs. 35.43	Rs. 35.59
Qatari Riyal	1	Rs. 36.46	Rs. 36.63
Thai Bhat	1	Rs. 3.86	Rs. 3.87
UAE Dirham	1	Rs. 36.18	Rs. 36.34
Malaysian Ringgit	1	Rs. 28.67	Rs. 28.80
South Korean Won	100	Rs. 10.15	Rs. 10.20
Swedish Kronar	1	Rs. 13.00	Rs. 13.06
Danish Kronar	1	Rs. 19.52	Rs. 19.60
Hong Kong Dollar	1	Rs. 17.02	Rs. 17.09
Kuwaiti Dinar	1	Rs. 432.14	Rs. 434.10
Bahrain Dinar	1	Rs. 352.45	Rs. 354.04

Note: Under the present system the open market exchange rates quoted by different banks may differ.

Girona edge Atletico, stay level with Real

AFP
Barcelona, Jan. 4

Shock Spanish title challengers Girona snatched a remarkable 4-3 victory over Atletico Madrid to keep pace with Real Madrid at the top of La Liga on Wednesday.

After Los Blancos edged Real Mallorca 1-0 thanks to Antonio Rudiger's goal, Ivan Martin's stoppage time strike ensured the Catalan minnows matched Carlo Ancelotti's side on 48 points from 19 matches.

Alvaro Morata hit a hat-trick for Atletico at Girona's tiny Montilivi stadium, but it was not enough as Martin found the top corner at the death to keep Girona firmly in the hunt for the title. Atletico, third, trail both Real and Girona by 10 points, as do champions Barcelona, fourth, who visit Las Palmas on Thursday.

Valery Fernandez, Savinho and Daley Blind netted for the hosts in a wild first half, with Morata twice scoring for Atletico.

The Spain international completed his treble early in the second period to pull Atletico level but Martin's last gasp heroics snatched Girona victory from a compelling clash.

"It's a historic night for us, for the city, for the province," Girona coach Michel told Movistar.

Girona, in only their fourth season in the top flight in their history and promoted in 2022, could have taken the lead inside the first minute. Valery curled home in the second minute beyond Jan Oblak with a fine strike from the edge of the area, before Morata pulled



Atletico level, staying onside by a whisker.

Girona were quickly back ahead with Savinho netting after 26 minutes, turning home after Oblak parried Martin's effort.

Blind turned home the third after Aleix Garcia's cross was cleverly flicked on to the back post by Dovbyk.

Morata was heavily involved for Atletico and after netting from Rodrigo de Paul's pass, struck again -- this time he was offside. The forward completed his hat-trick after the break with the aid of a slight deflection, after being sent through again by De Paul.

The game continued to flow end-to-end before Martin decided it, scrapping for an inch of space inside the area and prodding a finish into the top corner, with Oblak only able to watch as Girona's dream grew bigger still.

Elsewhere, Mallorca battled well against Real Madrid at the Santiago Bernabeu before Rudiger grabbed the hosts their victory. The defender headed home from a corner with 12 minutes remaining to settle a tight clash in which Mallorca twice hit the woodwork.

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SUPPLEMENT
Friday, January 5, 2024
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Carbon Trading For Sustainable Future | B



Chobhar Blues: A Good Reading | C

Transformative Funding For Education



Manjima Dhakal

Nepal faces several challenges in education financing, including insufficient funding, inequality, quality improvement, and administrative efficiency.

In Nepal, education discourse often revolves around the inadequacy of budgets. The conventional financing approach has raised concerns regarding insufficient funds for education. The government of Nepal spends about 11 per cent of the total budget on education. The amount is insufficient for free and compulsory quality education, as we assumed in the constitution. Stakeholders are demanding at least 20 per cent budget allocation in education. However, it's time to explore new approaches to education financing, as global practices suggest, which can be best for countries like ours with low financing. Innovative investment in education is becoming a prominent approach in developed nations like Finland, Denmark, and Norway, which have strong education systems. To drive positive changes in education in Nepal, innovative financing models are crucial.

There are several challenges associated with the traditional method. Traditional budget allocations, based on historical trends, may not keep up with these evolving needs, leading to insufficient funding for education. In traditional systems, almost 80 per cent of the allocated funds are used for administrative and operational expenses, leaving a smaller portion for direct educational activities. This inefficiency can hinder the improvement of educational infrastructure and resources. Likewise, traditional budget allocation models often lack flexibility and creativity. They may not encourage innovative approaches or adapt to changing educational requirements. And it also resulted in disparities in educational access and quality. In Nepal, the government allocates about 11 per cent of the total budget, where most of the budget is spent for administrative work, and as a result, the budget is not sufficient for academic work. Therefore, private sector involvement in education is also found in Nepal. Likewise, private financing plays a role in the education sector in Nepal. But it can also result in disparities in access to quality education. Nepal faces several challenges in education financing, including insufficient funding, inequality, quality improvement, and administrative efficiency.

A case study

Even some local governments in Nepal are taking extra initiatives. Suryadaya Municipality in Ilam, Nepal, has taken significant initiatives in the education sector, with a focus on enhancing access to quality education and connecting local agriculture with pedagogy.

The municipality introduced an impressive educational tool called the Interactive Panel Board. The Board enables students from multiple schools to join live math and science classes delivered by teachers from Phikkal Secondary School and Jyoti Secondary School. This innovative approach can help overcome geographical barriers and improve access to specialised interactive education, which also tackles the deficit and shortage of teachers. Rana Bahadur Rai, head of the municipality, said now students are not compelled to stay in leisure classes even if the schools don't have particular subject teachers.

The Innovation Centre is another impressive project. It has established an innovation centre with the primary goal of making the region an agricultural hub. Given the importance of agriculture in many rural areas, this initiative can lead to increased agricultural productivity and economic development. The centre can serve as a hub for research, training, and the dissemination of best practices in agriculture.

It's noteworthy that 65 per cent of students in Suryadaya Municipality are studying at community schools. These schools play a crucial role in rural areas, and focusing on improving the quality of education in community schools can contribute to equitable access to education for a majority of the students.

The municipality is unaware of innovative financing models, but these initiatives reflect a commitment to education, innovation, and agricultural development in the municipality.



Photo generated by AI

Concept

Innovative financing in education offers a solution to these challenges by introducing fresh and creative approaches to funding education. Innovative finance includes mechanisms and solutions that increase the volume, efficiency, and effectiveness of financial flows. There is no universal model for innovative financing; instead, authorities in each specific location can develop and implement a financing model that aligns with local needs and circumstances.

But innovative financing in education entails thinking creatively and unconventionally about how to raise and allocate funds to improve educational outcomes, access, and quality. These approaches aim to address the challenges and funding gaps that may exist in traditional education financing models. Innovative financing seeks to support educational initiatives and reforms, particularly in situations where government budgets alone may fall short of meeting the demands of a growing and evolving education system.

Innovative financing in education encompasses various creative methods, like receiving extra tax from areas like tourism, airlines, hotels, and others. Likewise, providing digital devices, internet access, and educational content to students, especially in remote areas, can minimise the budget expenditure as well as fulfil teachers' requirements, and collaboration between governments and private sector entities to fund and operate educational facilities, such as schools, universities, and vocational training centres, can benefit from philanthropic support.

Besides that, government-issued vouchers are also popular globally now, where the government gives a check or voucher to students while parents search for the best schools for them.

Creative financing approaches foster innovation both in funding models and in the development of new educational solutions. They encourage experimentation and creative thinking to find more effective and efficient ways to address educational challenges.

Innovative financing can promote greater equity in education by targeting resources where they are needed the most. For low-income countries facing budget constraints, innovative financing opens the door to a wider pool of capital sources.

And innovative financing models tie financial incentives to achieving specific educational outcomes. This ensures accountability and a results-driven approach, where investors or funders are rewarded based on the actual impact of the programmes they support.

As the municipality is doing its best out of its own model, educationalist Dr. Baburam Adhikari also suggested developing one's own model of innovative financing rather than copying from international practices. "We have to set the indicators of innovative financing according to our context rather than copying from others. Only self-motivated indications can be implemented successfully; therefore, we have to develop the indicators by keeping three-layer governments at the centre.

Dr. Bal Chandra Luitel, another educationist, suggests strengthening the public financing model that we are adopting now. This involves increasing investments in the education sector and optimising the allocation of resources to ensure that schools receive the necessary funds to improve both the quality and accessibility of education. "We have to explore additional revenue sources to strengthen public financing. One proposal is to consider implementing extra taxation in certain areas, such as the tourism and airline sectors. These targeted taxes can serve as dedicated sources of revenue specifically earmarked for the education sector, potentially providing the necessary financial boost to enhance educational facilities and resources.

Likewise, he suggested utilising technology for content development. Harnessing digital tools and resources can revolutionise how educational content is created and delivered. Another critical aspect that Dr. Luitel stresses is the importance of effective budget management. He suggests that the existing budget can be sufficient for addressing educational needs if it is managed efficiently and transparently. Proper budget management ensures that the available resources are used optimally, allowing for a greater impact in the education sector.

Lastly, Dr. Luitel recommends looking up to developed nations as examples. Many developed countries have a history of substantial and consistent investments in education, even during their development phases. Studying their approaches and best practices can provide valuable insights and guidance for Nepal as it seeks to strengthen its education system.

Dr. Pramod Bhatta, another educationist, advocates for the decentralisation of education in Nepal. He emphasises that local governments should play a more significant role in monitoring and overseeing the education system. This approach can increase transparency and accountability within the system, as local authorities are better positioned to understand and address the specific needs and challenges of their communities.

The arrangement of "Ghumti Teachers" who move from school to school may minimise the budget expenditure. The provision can be effective mainly in remote areas that have been facing teacher shortages most of the time.

Furthermore, Dr. Bhatta recommends implementing targeted programmes like 'Padhdai Kamaudai', earning together with learning. Such initiatives can help identify and support children who are out of school or at risk of dropping out. By providing tailored support to these students, Nepal can work towards a more inclusive and equitable education system. Dr. Bhatta also emphasises the importance of utilising technology in education management and delivery. This can include digital tools for administrative tasks as well as online or remote learning to reach students in remote areas and promote flexibility in education delivery.

Lastly, Dr. Bhatta suggests exploring the voucher system, where students receive educational vouchers that can be used in various schools. This approach can widen school choice and promote healthy competition among educational institutions, potentially leading to improved quality and innovation within the education sector. He said implementing these new models according to the needs of local levels can be taken as one's own model of innovative financing.

These expert suggestions encompass a wide range of strategies to enhance the education system in Nepal, including financing, governance, technology integration, and targeted programmes. The implementation of these approaches, in combination, holds the potential to significantly improve the quality and accessibility of education in the country.

International practice

A number of developed nations have adopted innovative financing models with great success. These models have led to improved access to quality education, enhanced infrastructure, and better educational outcomes. By embracing these global practices, countries like Nepal can learn from the experiences of others and adapt similar models to their specific contexts.

For example, the UK has been practicing financing models like education venture funds, debt conversion development bonds, diaspora bonds, and travel savings funds for development.

In Denmark, public support for students is excellent. The two main institutes responsible for dealing with student support are the agency and the ministry. The agency deals with student applications, communicates with educational institutions, pays out grants and loans, and writes budgets. The Ministry does the general planning and budgeting and is also in charge of any amendments to the system. Foreign students (unless under special status) are not able to use educational assistance. Of those able to use support, about 50 per cent take advantage of the loaning system.

Likewise, Norway's education system is mainly funded by public expenditure, with very little private funding. Public primary and secondary schools are free of charge. Only 3.3 percent of children in Norway attend private primary and lower secondary schools, and most private schools receive some state funding.

There are different practices around the world in terms of how government money is spent on education. One such practice is the voucher system.

Voucher system

According to the Organisation for Economic Co-operation and Development (OECD), 88 countries worldwide (25 out of 34 OECD members) have some form of voucher system in place. This system is also known as the School Choice Programme, as it allows students (parents) to choose their school.

Australia, Austria, Belgium, Canada, Chile, Colombia, Denmark, Estonia, Finland, France, Germany, Hong Kong, Hungary, Iceland, and Ireland are the countries that partially or fully embrace the voucher system. India, Japan, Korea, Luxembourg, Mexico, the Netherlands, New Zealand, Norway, Sweden, Switzerland, the UK, and the USA can also be placed on this list.

Implementation of the school voucher system in these countries is not uniform. Some offer vouchers to attend a private school of the student's choice, while others allow vouchers to be used only by religious schools or schools that serve minority, disadvantaged, or low-income students.

Voucher systems not only reduce the burden on the government to provide education but can also increase the efficiency and accountability of educational institutions. Children can go to the school of their choice.

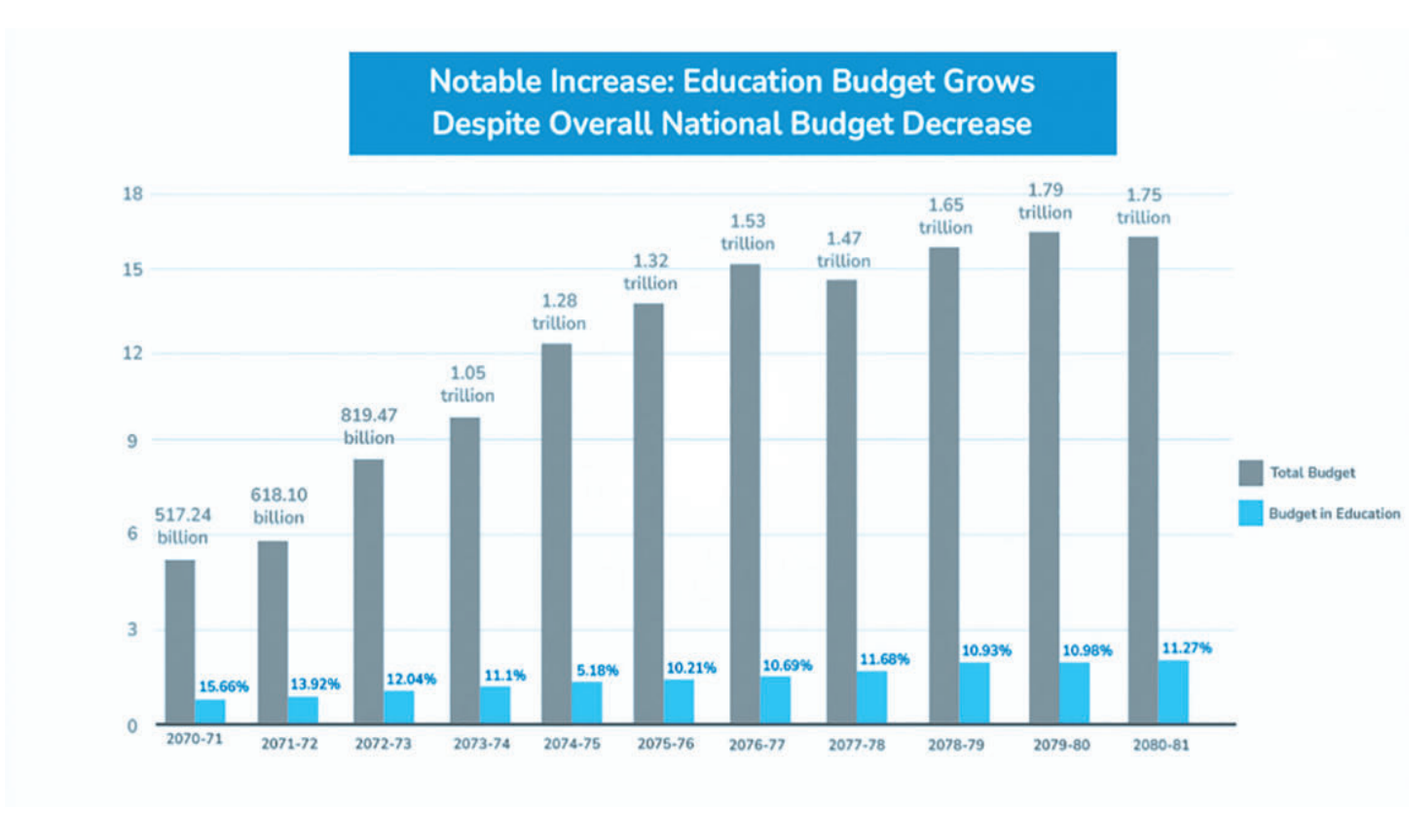
Efficient use of resources can reduce the cost of public education and increase teacher and student attendance at school. Most importantly, competition creates pressure for public schools to improve.

The government of Nepal spends about 11 per cent of the total budget on education. The global average is 17 per cent. Although lower than this, it is higher than the South Asian average (9 per cent). Looking at the budget for the last few years, it seems that the government of Nepal spends an average of 18,000 rupees annually on each student studying in public schools. It also provides separate scholarships and financial assistance for the poor and other identity groups.

Conclusion

In conclusion, the status of education financing in Nepal faces significant challenges, including insufficient funding, inequity, and administrative inefficiency. Experts have suggested and showcased innovative financing models through local initiatives to address these issues and bridge budget gaps. These models encompass strategies such as targeted taxation, technology integration, improved budget management, decentralisation, and voucher systems. Learning from global practices, countries like Nepal can adapt successful models to their unique contexts, as demonstrated in other countries. These innovative approaches hold the potential to improve the quality and accessibility of education, ensuring a better future for the youth of Nepal.

(Dhakal is a journalist at The Rising Nepal)

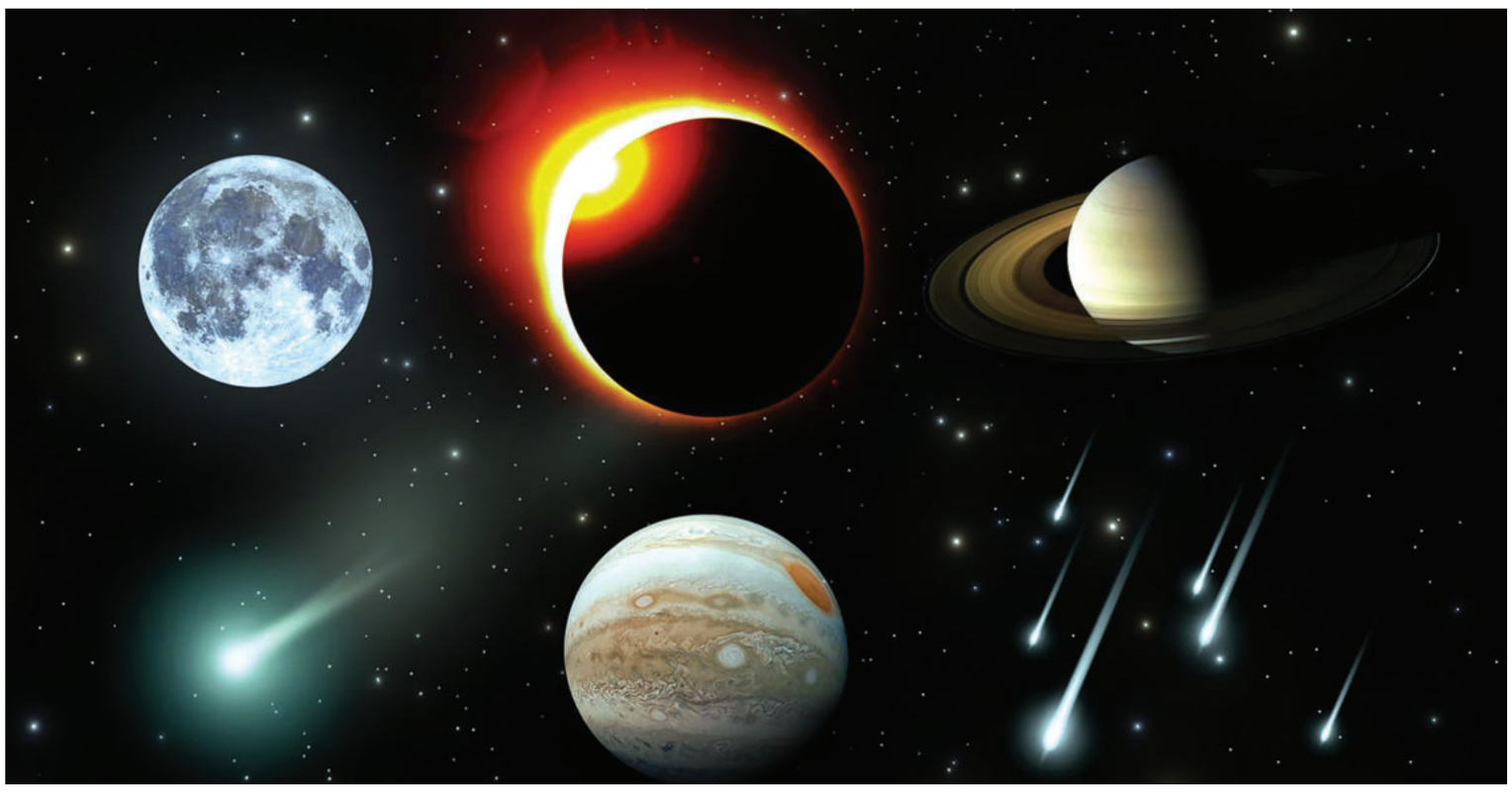


Source: edusanjal

Planet View And Meteor Watching



Dr. Rishi Shah



ASTRONOMY

As it darkens, the long night skies of this chilly winter month will provide excellent opportunities for stargazing, planet viewing, and meteor watching. The rocky planets Mercury, Venus, and Mars would be congregating in the pre-dawn sky during this first month of 2024. Both elusive planet Mercury and romantic Venus would be fleeting across the southern sector of the broad constellation Ophiuchus (serpent bearer) and the northern side of the constellation Sagittarius (archer). Mercury would reach its greatest western elongation from the sun on January 12. It would be the best time to marvel at Mercury since it would attain its highest place above the eastern horizon in the morning. The planet would otherwise lie low in the eastern sky just before sunrise before it would be lost in the solar haze. Planet Venus would be visible in the southeastern sky shortly before sunup. It would slowly be evanescent at daybreak. The red planet Mars will stay out of sight this month. It would be hugging the eastern horizon at daybreak. It would be marching across the northern section of sprawling Sagittarius during the day.

The mighty planet Jupiter, with its mesmerizing moons, could be observed in the southeastern sky after sunset. It would be ascending in the southern sky until midnight and would thereafter sink towards the western horizon. It would be resting relaxed in the southern region of the compact constellation Aries (ram).

> The mighty planet Jupiter, with its mesmerizing moons, could be observed in the southeastern sky after sunset.

The distant planet Uranus would be gleaming to its east. Planet Neptune would be lying below the curious circlet asterism of the constellation Pisces (fish), and the ringed planet Saturn would be standing in the southern segment of the constellation Aquarius (water bearer). They could be followed by strange scintillating spots of lambent lights among the twinkling stars. The ringed planet Saturn could be seen in the southwestern sky briefly after sundown. It would be descending towards the horizon and setting. Planet Uranus would be perceived in the eastern sky at dusk.

It would be climbing in the southern sky until late in the night. It would then creep towards the western horizon. Far-flung blue planet Neptune could be glimpsed in the southeastern sky after nightfall tersely. It would be slinking towards the horizon.

For one complete orbit (revolution) around the sun, our planet Earth would require simply 365.256 days, during which time it would have journeyed whooping 940 million kilometers. Earth's average speed along its track would indicate a meager 29.78 kilometers per second.

Earth would be closest to the Sun (perihelion) at fairly 147.1 million kilometers and farthest (aphelion) at a staggering 152.1 million kilometers. Earth would be nearest to the sun on January 3, 2024, when we would experience winter in the Northern Hemisphere. We would be most remote from the sun on July 5, 2024, during our summer. Clearly, the earth's distance from the sun would not be the predominant reason for our seasons.

Earth's path around the sun is not circular but elliptical. Thus, it is not earth's span from the sun that would trigger our winter and summer, but instead, the mere tilt of our planet's axis, amounting to circa 23.5 degrees with respect to its spin, would cause seasons. In winter, our part of the earth would be inclined away from the sun. In summer, the earth would lean toward the sun. The slight slant would alter the angle of sunlight falling on earth.

NIGHT SKY IN JANUARY

The Quadrantid meteor shower could stupefy fervent skygazers with up to forty fabulous meteors per hour at its peak, which would transpire this year from the late night of January 3 to the morning of January 4 in magnificent moonlight. Quadrantids have been allegedly produced by dust grains left behind by an asteroid dubbed 2003 EH1. The lucent last quarter waning gibbous moon, 55 per cent illuminated, would rise around midnight and shine through the rest of the night. It would wash away the fainter meteors, but patient onlookers could still savor the shiny show of sparkling shooting stars. They could be witnessed well from tenebrous locations after midnight. Meteors would exclusively exude from the constellation Bootes (herdsman). Quadrantids would usually be active between the end of December and the second week of January. The radiant of Quadrantids would soar in the north-northeast sky after midnight and be elevated eminently before day-start. It could also be imagined as residing in the now-obsolete constellation, Quadrans Muralis (Mural Quadrant). It would apparently make an approximate right angle with the circumpolar constellation Ursa Major (big bear or Sapta Rishi) and the amazing star Arcturus (Swati) shining serenely in the kite-mimicking constellation Bootes. Stars Merak (Pulaha) and Dubhe (Kratu) inhabiting constellation Ursa Major could point at Polaris (Pole Star or Dhruba Tara) dwelling in constellation Ursa Minor (little bear). Dutch American astronomer Peter Jenniskens had proposed that the parent body spawning Quadrantids would be an astounding asteroid nicknamed 2003 EH1, which was believed to be a decidedly dormant or extinct comet. The Lowell Observatory Near-Earth Object Search (LONEOS), based near Flagstaff, Arizona, had identified 2003 EH1. The asteroid would need a paltry 5.5 years to scamper around the sun. During its immediate approach to the sun, it would come within an immense 179.517 million kilometers. Arcturus would form one corner of the so-called Spring Triangle asterism, while the other shimmering star Spica in constellation Virgo (maiden) and resplendent star Regulus in constellation Leo (lion) would depict the other two corners. Located at Hammy 36.7 light-years from the Sun, Arcturus is a single-red giant aging star practically 7.1 billion years old that has used up its core hydrogen and evolved off the main sequence stage. Similar in mass to the sun, it has expanded enormously to 25 times its size. Its diameter would be about 35 million kilometers. Spica would be a spectroscopic binary star and a rotating ellipsoidal variable. It would contain two stars that are squeezed together to become egg-shaped rather than spherical. It would be outright 250 light-years away. Regulus would actually be a quirky quadruple star system composed of four stars that are organized into two pairs. They would lie ornately 79 light-years from the sun. Regulus, along with five distinguishably dimmer stars, have collectively been acclaimed as the sickle, which has been an asterism that would mystifyingly characterize the hypothetical head of a lion. The new moon would befall on January 11, while the full moon marking Shree Swastani Puja would begin to enthrall moon-lovers on January 25. This full moon has been popularly known as the wolf moon because, during this time of year, hungry wolf packs would be howling and roaming outside the settlement camps.

Large, stony main-belt arcane asteroid (flying between Mars and Jupiter) 354 Eleonora would be directly opposite the Sun (opposition) on January 20. It would coincidentally make its tight tryst with earth (termed its perigee) appear brightest in the night sky. It was divulged by the French astronomer Auguste Charlois on January 17, 1893, in Nice. Eleonora would be veritably 149.0 kilometers in diameter and conduct its single twirl every 4.28 hours. It would trudge around the Sun every 4.68 years, coming to the Sun's neighborhood at surely 372.49 million kilometers and being far away at plainly 465.25 million kilometers from the Sun. NASA has not yet classified Eleonora as potentially hazardous because its route would not bring it worrisomely to Earth's vicinity. Eleonora would become accessible in the evening, when it would rise above the eastern horizon. It would vault aloft in the sky at midnight above our southern horizon. It would become inaccessible in the early morning when it would slide towards the western horizon. It would be tumbling across the confounding cute constellations Cancer (crab) and Canis Minor (lesser dog), where the peculiar star Procyon (Manda) would be dazzling dramatically. It would be passing within approximately 231.88 million kilometers by earth. But still, Eleonora would look like a foggy object beyond the grasp of her naked eyes. Good binoculars or telescopes with a moderate aperture would be needed to pursue it passably. It would be refulgent by a 9-day-old waxing gibbous 76 percent fulgurating mysterious moon. Procyon would contain a white-hued main-sequence star hurtling around an oddly obscured white dwarf companion. This baffling binary stellar duo would be unerringly 11.46 light-years away from us.

(Dr. Shah is an academician at NAST and patron of NASO)

Carbon Trading For Sustainable Future



Suravi Rijal

As the global community confronts the pressing challenges of climate change, sustainable development has become more than just a buzzword; it's a critical imperative. The ever-increasing levels of greenhouse gas emissions, primarily carbon dioxide, are creating a host of environmental and socio-economic issues. The unsustainable levels of carbon emissions resulting from human activities such as industrial manufacturing, transportation, and energy production have contributed to the deterioration of the climate. Recognising the urgency to address this problem, governments, organisations, and individuals alike have sought solutions to reduce and mitigate their carbon footprint. One such solution that has gained momentum in recent years is carbon trading.

Concept

Carbon trading is an economically oriented approach aimed at addressing the challenge of global warming by curbing the release of greenhouse gases, notably carbon dioxide, stemming from the combustion of fossil fuels in the framework of carbon markets. Businesses and individuals have the opportunity to compensate for their emissions by acquiring carbon credits from organisations committed to diminishing or eradicating their own greenhouse gas outputs. This system essentially creates a financial incentive for emissions reduction and fosters environmental responsibility within a market-driven context.

Since the Kyoto Protocol, under the United Nations Framework Convention on Climate Change (UNFCCC), there has been a notable increase in the worldwide implementation of clean development mechanisms (CDM) and emissions trading systems. The targets for the first commitment period of the Kyoto Protocol covered emissions of the six greenhouse gases, including carbon dioxide.

Carbon trading is a market-based approach that aims to reduce greenhouse gas emissions by putting a price on carbon. It enables companies and governments to trade emission permits, which represent a certain amount of carbon dioxide (CO_2) emissions. By implementing a cap on total emissions and allowing entities to trade these permits, carbon trading creates a financial incentive for reducing emissions and investing in cleaner technologies.

If a company exceeds its allocated emissions limit, it can purchase extra permits from another company that has managed to reduce its emissions below its allocated limit. This transaction benefits both parties, as the emitting company avoids paying potentially higher fines for exceeding its limit, while the reducing company gains a financial reward for its efforts.

Carbon trading

In 2001, the government of Nepal entered into a significant agreement with the World Bank's Forest Carbon Partnership (FCP). This landmark Emission Reduction Payment Agreement (ERPA) paves the way for Nepal to receive up to US$45 million in support aimed at curbing carbon emissions resulting from deforestation and forest degradation. Over the course of the agreement, spanning until 2025, Nepal is expected to achieve a remarkable reduction of 9 million tons of carbon dioxide emissions, specifically within the Terai Arc Landscape. Under this agreement, Nepal will receive USD 5 for every ton of carbon dioxide emissions successfully mitigated.

Nepal as a least developed country has the opportunity to participate in the Reducing Emissions from Deforestation and Degradation (REDD) programme, which allows developed countries to purchase carbon offsets from countries like Nepal. Basically, REDD+ is a voluntary climate change mitigation framework developed by the UN Framework Convention on Climate Change (UNFCCC) that plays prominent role in the conservation and sustainable management of forests, and enhancement of forest carbon stocks in developing countries. In the pursuit of sustainable and greener futures India has made a significant step by introducing the Carbon Credit Trading Scheme (CCTS).

The Energy Conservation (Amendment) Bill, 2022, through which this innovative scheme is brought into force, gives the federal government the authority to create a framework for carbon trading. With the CCTS, India aims to create a thriving domestic carbon market, encouraging industries and entities to reduce their carbon emissions through a market-based approach.



Significance

One of the major benefits of carbon trading is that it unlocks the potential for sustainable development. By putting a price on carbon, it encourages industries to adopt cleaner technologies and energy sources, such as renewable energy, to reduce their emissions. This not only helps combat climate change but also fosters economic growth and job creation in the renewable energy sector.

Furthermore, carbon trading provides a source of funding for sustainable development initiatives. The revenue generated from the sale of emission permits can be reinvested in projects that promote sustainability, such as reforestation efforts, renewable energy infrastructure, or energy-efficient building programs. These investments not only lead to reduced emissions but also have positive social and economic impacts on local communities.

Carbon trading has opened doors to a new era of international collaboration through the exchange of carbon credits. This globally recognised tool is instrumental in bridging nations and unifying their efforts towards a common goal: mitigating the devastating impacts of climate change. Countries across the globe can participate in emissions trading schemes that facilitate the exchange of carbon credits, solidifying international partnerships in the face of this worldwide crisis. Such collaborations strengthen the ties between nations and encourage the transfer of cleantech expertise, research, and resources. Also, the mechanism of carbon credits intersects with goal 7, goal 8, goal 13 and goal 15 of Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs).

Carbon trading facilitates such collaboration at international as well as at regional levels. These schemes bring nations together, transcending geopolitical boundaries. The European Union's Emission Trading System (EU ETS) is one of the world's largest carbon market which works on 'cap' and 'trade' principles. It aims to make polluters pay for their greenhouse gas emissions, helps bring emissions down and generates revenue to finance the EU's green transition. The EU member states under European Climate Law aim to become climate neutral by 2050.

Nepal has a vast potential for renewable energy, such as hydropower, solar, and wind energy. By investing in these renewable energy projects, Nepal can reduce its dependency on fossil fuel-based energy sources and generate carbon credits, which can then be sold in the international market. Nepal has set a goal to achieve net zero carbon emissions by 2045, which aligns with the growing global focus on climate change mitigation. Many developed nations have made commitments to reduce their emissions and are actively looking for ways to achieve these targets. By participating in global carbon markets, Nepal can contribute to these efforts and receive financial support for its sustainable development initiatives. The participation in carbon trading can provide Nepal with access to climate finance and technology transfer. Developed countries often channel funds to developing nations through mechanisms like the Green Climate Fund to support their climate change mitigation and adaptation efforts. By engaging in carbon trading, Nepal can demonstrate its commitment to reducing emissions and attract financial assistance to support its transition to a low-carbon economy.

Positive impacts

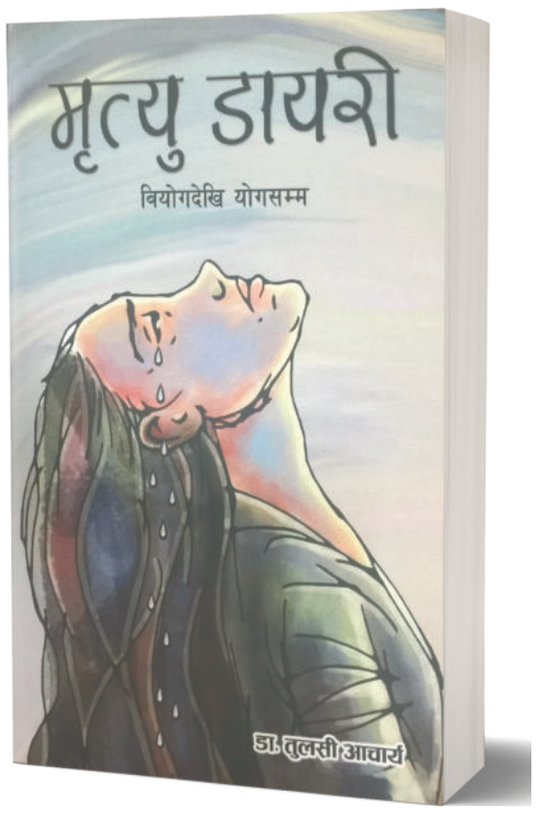
In order to fully harness the potential of carbon trading, governments and organisations shall establish the frameworks that ensure transparency, accountability, and integrity in the carbon market by preventing any fraudulent activities or market manipulation. Additionally, it is important to ensure that the benefits of carbon trading reach local communities and vulnerable populations. Investments generated through the sale of carbon credits should be directed toward projects that have positive social and economic impacts. This includes initiatives that promote community development, enhance livelihoods, and protect the rights of indigenous peoples and local communities.

(The author is a BALLB student at Kathmandu School of Law.)

Story Of Pain And Tragedy



Narayan Prasad Ghimire



Death is defined and interpreted in many ways. Medical science sees it as a complete dysfunction of vital organs, leading to lifelessness, while spiritual perspectives regard it as a journey to the next world. It is believed that the fate of the dead in Yamalok is determined by their deeds in the Martyalok. Where there is life, there is death. It is unavoidable, but untimely death is a disaster. It is disastrous indeed for the relatives who are loved and brought up by the departed.

There are myriad causes of death, ranging from natural calamities to human-caused accidents. In many cases, knowingly or innocently, people make themselves diseased, leading to the termination of their lives.

Whatever kind of death we face, it is appalling and agonizing. Life, despite challenges and hostilities, is full of love that emotionally binds family members and relatives.

It is therefore a huge emotional setback for one when he or she loses loved ones.

The book under review, 'Mrityu Diary: Biyogdekhi Yogsamma' penned by Dr. Tulasi Acharya, revolves around the above issues, with a special focus on death. The description of death is incomplete if it is not compared to life and love. These issues are dwelt on thoroughly while explaining suffering, parental care and fuss, and children's responsibility towards parents in the book, where there is a story of a double disaster—the deaths of parents in five months' gap—to a daughter.

The diary or book is written by a relative, the son-in-law (jwai) of the victims: the father-in-law (Sasura) dies at the age of 62, and the mother-in-law (Sasu) dies at 51. The father-in-law dies after five months of the passage of the mother-in-law. As the mother-in-law died all of a sudden, the suffering began in the daughter's life.

It is the account of a witness to the tragedy that befell his wife. The book is therefore a real story involving parents, two daughters, and two sons-in-law. The events take place in Pokhara and Kathmandu cities.

Time is so cruel that Nepal was engulfed by COVID-19, spreading terror and threats to life as the young ones strive to treat diseased seniors. The two daughters and two sons-in-law continue engaging with the treatment of an ailing father or father-in-law who suffers from cancer, despite the utmost adversity.

The roles of parents and subsequent traumatic experiences, especially those of the writer's spouse, are centred in the book.

Her mother's death comes more unexpectedly than that of her father's, as there were no symptoms or signals of any illness in her, while her fathers was later detected to have cancer. Emotionally enfeebled after the mother's death, the agonised state of the daughter, Kripa, is shed light by the writer, who also involves assuaging the spouse's pain.

Kripa's husband and youngest son-in-law, who writes the book, has to make frequent travels to and from Kathmandu and Pokhara despite his recent opportunity to teach at a university in the US after acquiring a PhD. He also faces the question of whether to quit his job in the US and continue caring for and collaborating with his wife, who has faced unprecedented tragedy in life. Luckily, his boss allows virtual teaching, citing his quandary and crisis.

In addition to the suffering faced by the two daughters after the sudden passing away of their parents, the book talks in length about Nepal's health system, which is full of hassles for patients, and gender bias. As the couple meeting untimely deaths had no sons, the daughters had no option but to carry out additional responsibilities.

However, the entrenched gender bias in Nepali society grates the writer's wife, Kripa, when she is not allowed to mourn her father's death equally as her senior sister during the death ritual of kiriya (obsequy). She was even censured that if she observed obsequy for more than five days, the dead ones (pitris) would face problems! Kripa also writes a media article about the discrimination she faces while observing pritri karma.

The writer is engrossed in life, death, and meaningful life, with extensive references from philosophers, poets, essayists, and ethicists. The allusions range from a revered Hindu scripture, 'Mahabharat', and from 'Waste Land', a seminal modern poem by TS Eliot. The invocation of philosophy on the termination of life and yearning to seek meaning makes the book meditative and literary.

"The views of eminent figures indicate that living a meaningful life is fostering humanity, understanding others' sorrow, and responding properly to the birth (life) and death of anyone who undergoes anguish," the writer states (p. 244).

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> The writer is engrossed in life, death, and meaningful life, with extensive references from philosophers, poets, essayists, and ethicists.

> As the book is a diary on death, it relates much about the throes of the person facing imminent death. But it fails to adequately share the 'lived experience' of death—burnout, spasm, frantic pain, and throes undergone by the person in the ultimate days of life.

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'Lived experience' is the firsthand personal experience. But the 'live experience' or the indirect experience of suffering is described more.

Although callous death comes to claim his life by making his vital organs non-functional, he does not explain or even share.

He seems to welcome death, but daughters and relatives are panicked by his pain and afraid of death and the subsequent loss of attachment and emotion.

Losing a mother and father in a five-month' gap is the biggest tragedy in one's life, which is described meticulously in this book. Finally, the reader can wonder: Is the book a diary or literary work? It delves into both genres.

The literary features of fiction have lifted it out of mundane death details, while the notes on death bring lively facts.

It is a memoir as well. The narration of tragedy with a special application of suspense, climax, and denouement finely draws traits of fiction from this oeuvre.

Research is another equally important aspect of this memoir, where the writer studies much on pancreatic cancer, the influential people losing lives to this sort of cancer, palliative care with the administration of 'morphine' and even the experience of a doctor while undergoing death pangs of cancer. The memoir is the writer's honour to his spouse's devotion to parents, which reflects many such stories in our society.

The book is published by Bhundipuran Prakashan.

Chobhar Blues: A Good Reading

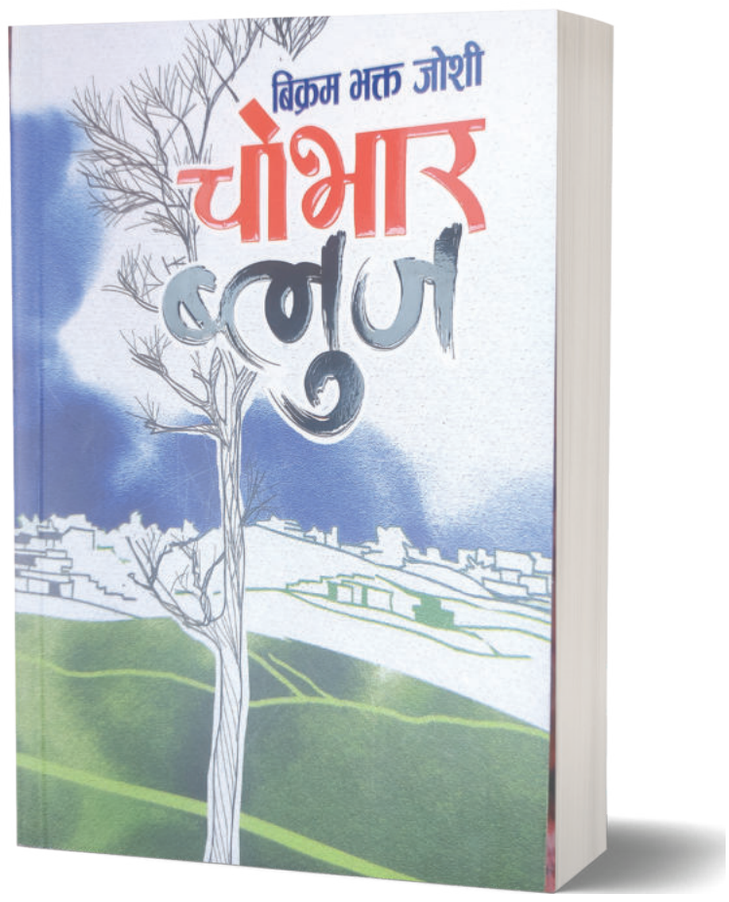


Bishnu Gautam

Chobhar Blues, a collection of stories by Bikram Bhakta Joshi, is a good read. Published by Sahitya Post, the book gives an unconventional test to its readers. No reader can rightly guess the ending of each story even after reading half of it. And if one tries to do so, he is sure to be wrong. Of course, an unexpected ending is the main feature of all the stories included in the collection.

Interestingly, it is the debut literary work of a banker by profession and an engineer by study, but it can captivate the readers. Bikram Bhakta studied engineering. But later, he became a banker. A man with a deep passion for literature, he also quit the job of a banker and jumped into the literary world as a learner.

The book under review, published last year, is his first work. However, he has succeeded in winning the hearts of readers with his debut work. Like his life, the 19 short stories included in this collection do not move in a straight line. So, the readers cannot rightly guess the ending of the stories. They swirl like the flooded streams of summer.



Most of his stories tell the tale of the pains of the people. The first story, Utsarga, has a tale of poor, lonely Lady Goma, who has nothing other than a few goats to live with in a hut at Pharsidol. She is alone because she was unable to tie the nuptial knot because she had a small brother to bring up when she was of marriageable age. But her brother went overseas to stay with his son, leaving his old sister Goma alone. Similarly, there is a story of an old goat herder in Bosandanad. Likewise, in Sunko Poko, there is a character named Sante, a poor man who dared to jump into floods in the hope of getting some gold by saving a bundle of gold from the sinking house in Pune. But neither he came up with gold nor his life; we went missing in the flood. In other stories, there are Harke, Bange, and Bisancha, who have been living through the pains of poverty and other problems in the hope of overcoming them one day, which never comes in their lives. There is also a story named Morokwal (more equal), which deals with the animal world similar to the Animal Farm of George Orwell.

Of course, story writer Joshi has presented not only the story of poverty and loneliness but also the betrayal of love. Chobhar Blues and Anichchhit Samabandh are the stories of such a betrayal. As his stories are full of pain, they end in tragedies.

However, as said above, most of the stories do not move ahead in a straight line. They take unexpected twists and turns, confusing the readers, as the plots of the stories change unexpectedly. In Anichchhit Sambandh, two men who have married their ex-girlfriends happened to share the same table while drinking in the evening. Likewise, in Planner Fantasy, the story writer all of a sudden turns into a wise sage and starts roaming in the sky of Kathmandu.

While telling the stories of men and women, the author has beautifully presented the life and culture of the people of the Kathmandu Valley. The settings and characters of almost all stories are from the Kathmandu Valley. While telling the stories of people, Joshi has beautifully explored the cultural and geographical beauties of the valley. His story, Khyak, Manchhe Ra Kukur, tells many things about the cultural aspects of the valley people.

As the stories are focused more on the Kathmandu Valley, its people, lifestyles, and culture, the writer has given insights into many of the cultural practices as well as the impacts of modernity. Joshi has also used Newari words in abundance. He has also used English words, which are commonly used by the learned men and women of today. Hence, his stories are about both the people of the older and younger generations and are relevant to all readers.

- D. N. Lohani

FUTURE WATCH

(Based on birth names)

January 5th to 11th 2024

ARIES — Fear and confusion can reside within you, delaying your success. You will only retain partial progress. The first two days will contain progress. The remaining period will comprise challenges. The study will gradually advance.

TAURUS — Major tasks will be completed successfully. Health concerns for yourself or your family will increase expenses. Decisive ability will guide you ahead. Trade and profession will both turn profitable. Job will provide some support.

GEMINI — Expenditure will surpass income. Opponents will remain active. Don't trust everyone completely. Travel is in store, but it may not yield much return. Study will take a progressive course.

CANCER — Initially Health disorders are predicted to cause some expenses. circumstances will improve on Sunday afternoon. Trade and profession will both turn profitable. Religious travel can take place. The job will contain concerns.

LEO — Work will be completed after causing expenses. You will find it difficult to save. Children's education will increase expenses. You will be keen to travel abroad. The love life will take a progressive course. A new friend can join the circle.

VIRGO — Handle valuable goods cautiously during the initial period. circumstances will improve from Sunday. You may have to endure a stomach disorder during the concluding period. The profession will yield some return.

LIBRA — Celebration and recreational get-togethers with interesting ones will make the start pleasant. Undertaken assignments will be completed successfully. The family will cooperate. Good friends can join your circle. Important meetings can take place toward the end.

SCORPIO — You will find it difficult to save. The business will yield a limited return. Distant friends will provide great support. Employees will remain dissatisfied with their progress. Recreational activities will attract you.

SAGITTARIUS — Prevailing confusion will not cause any problems. You will enjoy a partial gain. Study will take a progressive course. Some of you will succeed in going abroad. The love life will take a progressive course.

CAPRICORN — Work will be completed after causing extra expenses. A new venture will face restraint, so it's better to wait some time. Employees will observe an ordinary period. The expenditure level will rise toward the end.

AQUARIUS — Major tasks will be completed successfully. Travel to the west is likely. Don't expect much support from relatives. Trade and profession will both turn profitable. Additional investment will pay off.

PISCES — Progress will be lower than expectations. With some effort, writing skills will improve. Study will take a progressive course. You will be eager to gain new knowledge. Investments will yield returns.

Asian Openbill Sanctuary In Kapilvastu



Rajesh Dhungana

Kapilvastu, an ancient city in Nepal, has rich biodiversity and is a habitat for various bird species and small animals. Among its notable physical features is the expansive Jagadishpur wetland, the largest man-made bird sanctuary in the area, surrounded by small lakes, ponds, canals, and rivers. The region is renowned for its cultivation of paddy, wheat, and mustard, creating an environment conducive to the proliferation of snails.

One prominent resident bird found in the area is the Asian openbill, scientifically known as "Anastomus oscitans" and locally referred to as "Ghughifor" in Nepali or "Ghoghila" in the local language. This large wading bird, a member of the stork family Ciconiidae, lives in groups, often resting on trees across the landscape. The Asian Openbill's primary diet is snails, fish, and small aquatic creatures, including freshwater crabs.

In the winter, migratory birds visit Jagadishpur wetlands, with some opting to make it their permanent home. This influx enhances the ecological diversity of the region. The Asian openbills are useful for Kapilvastu farms because their droppings, which are full of nutrients like phosphorus and nitrogen, gather under their nesting trees. When it rains, these nutrients flow into the fields, making the soil better for farming and benefiting the local farmers a lot.

Historically, the Asian openbill was first definitively recorded in Nepal in Kuria Mahan of Chitwan National Park in 1964–65. Subsequent research by ornithologists documented their presence in various locations, both within and outside protected areas, including Rupandehi and Kapilvastu. According to local residents, the population of Asian openbills has increased significantly in recent years, emphasising the importance of preserving their habitat and recognising their ecological contributions to agriculture.





Features

The main distinguishing features of the Asian openbill are its long bill and legs and the hollow point of its bill. Its feathers are white, grey, and black, especially the wings. During breeding season, this bird is very bright, and the legs are light pink. The tail of this bird has 12 feathers and is tufted into a gland. After breeding, their colour becomes lighter, and the droppings appear grey. These birds are bigger and fatter than great egrets and smaller than cranes. This bird is called an openbill because of the opening in the middle of its beak. The shape of the beak helps the snail break out of its hard shell and eat it. This bird is completely carnivorous.

The cutting edges of mandibles have a fine, brush-like structure that gives them a better grip on snail shells. These birds look like white storks or oriental storks from a distance. Asian openbills are broad-winged and depend on hovering between warm air thermals for sustained flight. This bird rests in flocks while sitting in trees. The average body length of the Asian openbill is about 68 to 81 cm. Its wingspan is 147 to 149 cm, and its weight ranges from 1.3 kg to 8.9 kg. This bird stands at a height of 68 cm.

Ecology and habitat

Asian openbills tend to ascend thermals during the warmer part of the day and descend quickly to their feeding areas. Groups of birds may forage together in shallow water or marshland, where they can walk slowly and steadily. Asian openbills feed mainly on large molluscs, especially Pila species, and they use the tip of their beak to separate the shell from the mollusc's body. The lower tip of the beak is often turned to the right. The tip is inserted into the snail's shell, and the body is pulled out with the bill underwater. Thomas Caverhill Jerdon, an ornithologist, mentions that this bird is able to catch snails even with a blindfold. Small snails are often swallowed whole by this bird.

This bird is found in Nepal, Bangladesh, Cambodia, Bhutan, Laos, India, Myanmar, Sri Lanka, Pakistan, Vietnam, and Thailand. This bird is a resident that migrates locally depending on the water conditions.

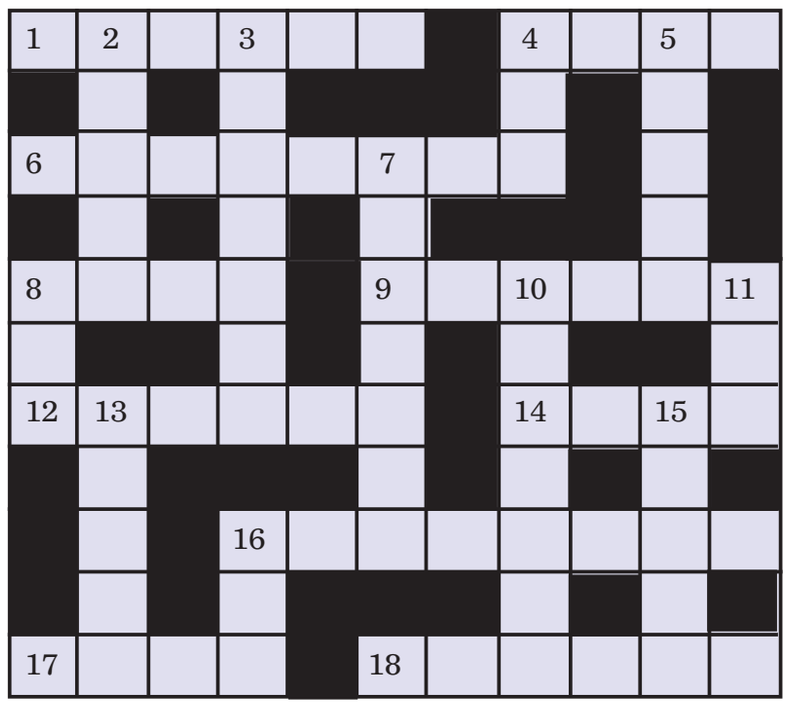
Breeding

The Asian openbill faces severe threats, primarily from the loss and degradation of wetlands, ponds, and lakes, coupled with tree felling, illegal hunting, and pesticide use in agricultural fields. The species is particularly vulnerable due to a lack of public awareness, leading to locals climbing trees, creating obstacles, and stealing eggs and chicks. Additionally, young chicks in nests are preyed upon by various birds of prey like imperial, steppe, and great-spotted eagles. Samjhana Kawan, a biologist with extensive experience researching large bird species, identifies Kapilvastu as an ideal habitat for the Asian openbill. This district boasts the highest number of lakes and ponds among Nepal's lowland regions, supporting massive paddy plantations through irrigation canals and boreholes during the monsoon.

The wetlands, paddy fields, and scattered tree patches with tall trees like Peepal (Ficus religiosa) and Seemal (Bombax ceiba) provide an optimal environment for both the Asian open-bill and its prey, the apple snail (Pila globosa). Despite being widely distributed, the apple snail faces harvesting pressure, particularly from the Tharu community, which makes up 12.3 per cent of the district's population. Notably, Kapilvastu hosts more than 80 Asian openbill nests in a single tree, underscoring its significance as a highly suitable habitat for this species.

(The author is a wildlife photographer. The photos used in this article are by the author himself.)

TRN CROSSWORD PUZZLE NO. 1772



Name .....

Address .....

Signature .....

Last date of entry:
January 10, 2024

Win a prize of Rs. 600. In case there are more than one correct entry the prize will be split into three sums of Rs. 200 each. The winner will be selected by a lucky draw. Only cuttings (not photo copy) that include the Crossword Puzzle no. will be accepted.

Across

1. Make more modern
4. Shake abruptly
6. Attack in deceitful manner
8. Facts
9. Material prosperity
12. Evades rules
14. In addition
16. Your recorded lineage
17. Correct language
18. Make a comment

Down

2. A shopping centre
3. Hard to deal with
4. Vaccinate
5. Smallest in amount
7. To be very tall
8. Stop living
10. A mixture
11. An American pay television network
13. Well founded
15. Guide the course of
16. Set in competition with

Solutions to TRN Crossword Puzzle No. 1771

ACROSS: 1. ASYLUM 4. RARE 6. CROSSING 8. YETI 9. FIGURE 12. WINNER 14. ICON 16. SCORPION 17. SIGN 18. POETRY

DOWN: 2. SURGE 3. LESBIAN 4. RIG 5. REFER 7. INFERNO 8. YAW 10. GLIMPSE 11. EON 13. INDRI 15. ODOUR 16. SIN

LUCKY WINNER

Mahendra Kumari Nath
Sheela Shrestha
Bal Krishna Shrestha

ALL CORRECT ANSWER

Kumari Nirmala Giri, Khadendra Nath, Sunil Sharma Bhattarai, Smriti Shrestha, Surya Shakya, Archana Devi Shrestha

CREATIVE CORNER



Ligya Bajimaya, Grade I, LIFE School Dhobighat, Lalitpur



Shaman Paudel, Grade V, Occidental Public School Anamnagar, Kathmandu

TRN PUZZLE NUMBER-404

All you have to do is to fill up in the seven boxes below with the numbers in such a way that the sum will be 553 whether you go diagonally, horizontally or vertically. The numbers should be 55 to 103 between. The number should not be used twice.

	93	102	55	64	73	
92						83
100	60		71		89	91
		70		88		
67	69				98	58
75		86	95	97		66

63	72	81	34	43	52	61
71	80	40	42	51	60	62
79	39	41	50	59	68	70
38	47	49	58	67	69	78
46	48	57	66	75	77	37
54	56	65	74	76	36	45
55	64	73	82	35	44	53

TRN PUZZLE SOLUTION-403

Prepared by: Bishwo Nath Kharel

Western Dreams In Youths



Lizala Maharjan

According to the Economic Survey 2022/23, above 15 per cent of Nepal's population is below the absolute poverty line, which means these populations live below $1.90 a day.

In today's world, it seems that a large number of youths are drawn towards the Western world. Western culture has influenced today's generation in many respects. They romanticise the Western world as the ideal place to sustain their lives. What actually does western society have? "Romanticism towards the Western world" generally means the idealised perception of the people towards the Western world, where the positive aspects are exaggerated more while the negative aspects are suppressed. Many young people, especially from countries like Nepal, tend to see the grass greener on the other side and are too quick to idealise the Western world.

But is seeing the West through rose-coloured glasses really a good sign for a country like Nepal?

If you ask the students about their future, most of their answers would be to fly off to the West and start a new life there. It's like their coping mechanism to fly off to the West in order to escape the reality of their present condition. According to the Economic Survey 2022/23, above 15 per cent of Nepal's population is below the absolute poverty line, which means these populations live below $1.90 a day. So, for people like them, it is quite obvious to idealise the Western world to escape the predicament that they are struggling with.

They tend to perceive the Western world in the form of new hopes for opportunities and freedom.

There are a number of reasons why Nepali youths are scrambling abroad. Number one is their exposure to the idealised portrayal of the Western world. Today, the social media generation tends to live their "online life" more than their real life. Many youngsters are being exposed to things that are inappropriate for them. They don't know how to differentiate between right and wrong. The media has portrayed western life as the "ideal lifestyle."

It is shown that people in the West live in big mansions and lavish homes, drive expensive cars, have huge celebrations for the smallest things, wear trendy clothes, and much more. This has created a fake impression about the Western world among youths today. They have glamorised the West as being free from problems like poverty, crime, and social inequality.

It seems that people are building castles in the air. They are in delusion, levitating in unrealistic fantasy about the Western world, which exists nowhere but only in their imagination. While busy romanticising the West, they tend to forget the hardships the people living there have to face. The West is a diverse and complex region with its own share of problems and challenges.

The media has neglected to show the harsh reality of the Western world. They have failed to paint the full picture of the Western world, where they have only portrayed the positive aspects and not the negative aspects like social divisions, racial discrimination, gun violence, economic disparities, and mental health challenges.

In order to put a full stop to this, we all need to work together to acknowledge and address this issue. This false idealisation has already done much damage to this generation, and it is in our hands to put an end to it. Introducing media literacy education at schools can be the ice-breaking step in this situation.

Students are the building blocks of the future, and teaching young minds at school about this situation will help to combat it. It can give them knowledge on how one can critically analyse the things portrayed by the media and break the idealistic stereotypes of the Western world.

We must also motivate today's generation to broaden their perspective on burning topics like these and promote other sources of information, like books, rather than the media alone.

In this regard, the government must also acknowledge this problem and help the youngsters solve it. If we all collectively work together, then we can definitely empower people by breaking the unrealistic fantasy and romanticism of people towards the Western world and building a more realistic and original perspective about it among people.

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